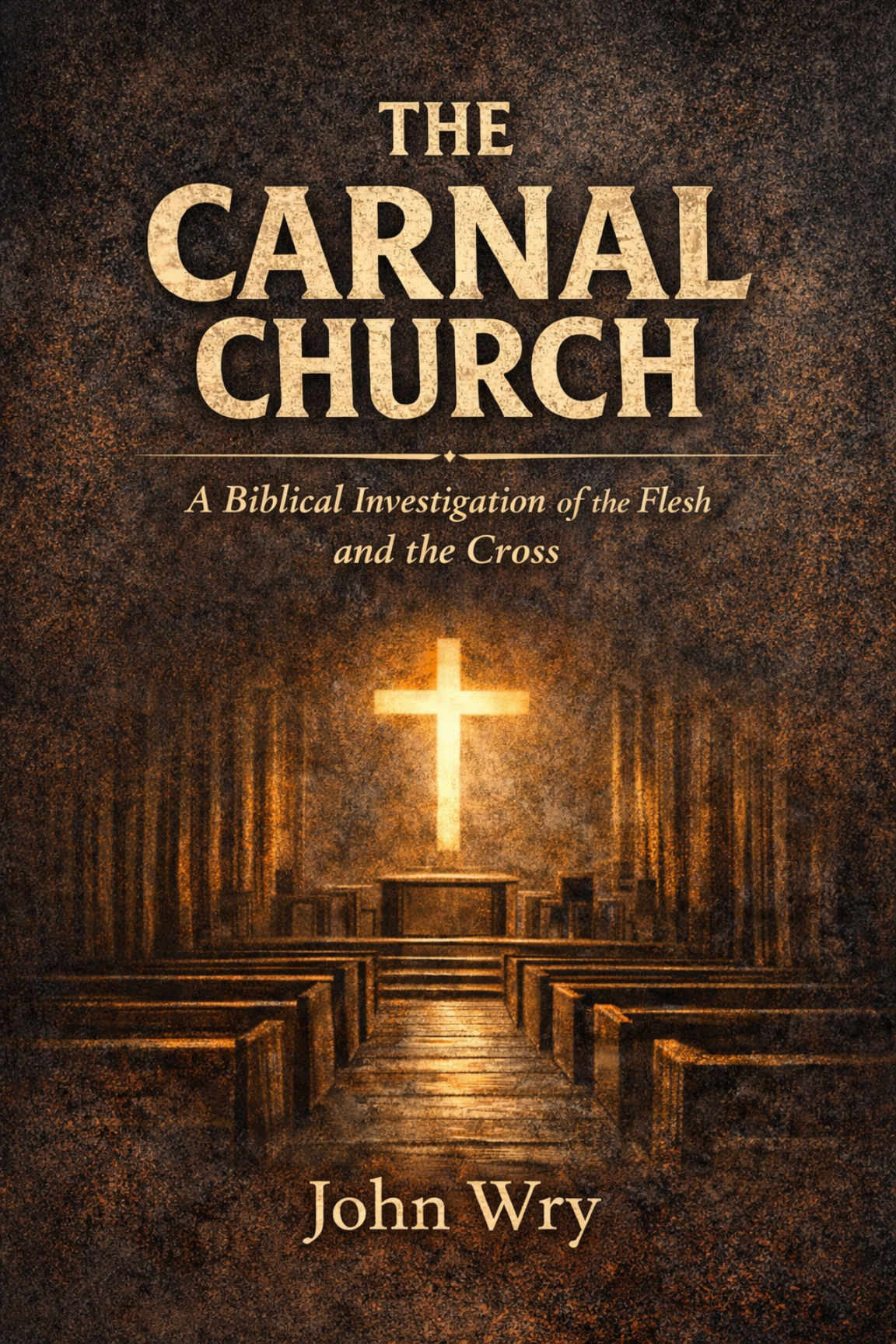


THE CARNAL CHURCH

*A Biblical Investigation of the Flesh
and the Cross*



John Wry

The Carnal Church

A Biblical Investigation of the flesh and the
cross

First edition
Copyright © 2026 John Wry

The Bible quotations are taken from the New American
Standard Bible (NASB).

This book may be freely shared in digital format, provided it is
not altered.

Dedicated to my wife Nelly,
who has always been by my side.

&

For those students
who stood firm in the gospel
no matter the cost.

Content

1	Prologue	7
2	The Café	9
3	Why Corinth?	21
4	What Is the Flesh?	32
5	Tracing the Flesh	42
6	Religious Flesh	53
7	The Works of the Flesh	61
8	By Their Fruit	72
9	Diagnosing a Church	80

10	The Lively Church	89
11	The Corinth Question	98
12	The Divided Church	108
13	The Serious Church	118
14	The Correct Church	128
15	The Successful Church	139
16	What Do We Mean by “Flesh”?	149
17	Four Definitions	160
18	The Passage They Couldn’t Ignore	172
19	The Passage That Made Them Uncomfortable	182
20	The List They Didn’t Expect	193
21	Carnality Management	203
22	When Carnality Tries to Cure Carnality	218

23	The Cross Paul Would Not Leave	230
24	The Cross Does Not Bow to Carnality	241
25	The Cross Is Not Deceived by Carnality	251
26	The Cross Confronts Carnality	262
27	The Cross Disarms Carnality	271
28	The Cross Protects From Carnality	281
29	Why Carnality Management Still Exists	290
30	Grace Has Made the Difference	299
31	What I Learned About the Carnal Church	308

Chapter 1

Prologue

Over the past several years I have watched something troubling unfold.

Young believers who had discovered the gospel with fresh clarity were sent to visit churches as part of their ministry training.

What happened next surprised all of us.

Some were welcomed.

But many were not.

They were told they spoke too much about grace.

That the gospel they shared sounded dangerous.

That it did not emphasize effort strongly enough.

Some were quietly warned.

Others were openly rejected.

A few were eventually pushed out of their churches entirely.

None of them had changed the message of Scripture.

They had simply begun to take it seriously.

Those events forced a question I could no longer ignore.

If the gospel is truly the power of God unto salvation, why does it sometimes feel unwelcome in the very place that claims to proclaim it?

That question began a journey.

The pages that follow are the record of that journey.

Chapter 2

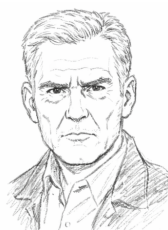
The Café



Adrián



Elías



Matías



Marcos

Adrián was already talking before anyone else had even arrived.

Standing at the counter.

One elbow on the wood, coffee in one hand, explaining something to the girl behind the register like they had known each other for years.

She was laughing while trying not to spill the coffee she was pouring.

"I'm serious," Adrián said. "If you burn this one too I'm switching cafés."

"You say that every week."

"And yet here I am."

She slid the cup across the counter.

Adrián lifted it, inspected it carefully, then nodded.

"Well look at that. You *can* learn."

She rolled her eyes.

"You're impossible."

"That's what my mother says."

A man at a nearby table chuckled quietly.

"You talk to everyone like you've known them forever?"

Adrián turned toward him.

"No," he said. "Some people I wait at least five minutes."

The man laughed.

Adrián finally took a sip.

He closed his eyes for a second.

“Alright,” he said softly. “That’s better.”

Just then the bell above the café door rang.

Adrián looked up immediately.

“Elías!”

Elías stepped inside, closing the door behind him and pausing a moment while his eyes adjusted to the light in the room. He looked around the café the way some people do when they like to understand a place before sitting down in it.

When he saw Adrián he shook his head slightly.

“You’ve already made friends.”

“Of course.”

Adrián lifted his cup.

“You want coffee?”

“I’ll get my own.”

“Suit yourself. But this place is dangerous.”

Elías raised an eyebrow.

“Dangerous?”

“Yes.”

Adrián lowered his voice.

“If you come here too often you might start enjoying life.”

Elías allowed himself a small smile and walked to the counter.

A few minutes later he joined Adrián at the table by the window.

“You’re late,” Adrián said.

“I’m not late.”

“You are if I’m already on my second cup.”

“You’re always on your second cup.”

“That’s because life requires preparation.”

“How are you my friend? It’s nice to see you.”

“ ‘Bout the same, cant’ complain”

The bell rang again.

A man stepped inside carrying a small travel bag.

He paused just inside the door, scanning the room quickly before spotting them.

Adrián lifted his hand.

“There he is.”

Marcos nodded once and walked over.

“You two started without me?”

“We were discussing important matters,” Adrián said.

“Coffee?”

“No,” Adrián said. “Civilization.”

Marcos set his bag down.

“I’ll take coffee.”

“Good decision.”

Marcos went to the counter.

Adrián leaned back in his chair.

“You know what’s strange?” he said.

“What.”

“You can tell a lot about a person by how they order coffee.”

Elías looked at him.

“I’m sure you can.”

“If they add too much sugar they’re hiding something.”

“You just made that up.”

“Yes.”

“But it sounded convincing.”

“That’s a gift.”

Marcos returned with his coffee and sat down.

Before anyone said anything else, the bell above the door rang

again.

Matías stepped inside.

He stood near the door for a moment, letting his eyes adjust before he spotted the table.

Adrián raised both hands.

“Finally.”

Matías walked over and set his bag down.

“Sorry I got delayed.”

“We’ve been here ten minutes.”

“You said two.”

“That was emotional time.”

Matías sat.

Now the four of them were there.

They had met at the same table in same café for years. This was their man-time. They would often just talk about whatever matters of life came to mind. Sometimes, however, they got into some pretty heavy discussions. They loved it!

For a moment nobody spoke.

Not awkward.

Just the quiet that comes when people who know each other

well sit down at the same table again.

Adrián finally broke it.

“You know what I noticed traveling last week?”

“That you talk too much?” Marcos said.

“That too.”

Adrián took another sip of coffee.

“But I visited a church while I was there.”

“Really? ,” Marcos said.

“Yeah, it was impressive.”

“Impressive how?” Elías asked.

Adrián shrugged.

“I don’t know. Alive, I guess.”

“Alive,” Elías repeated.

“Yes.”

“That’s a technical term.”

“Very technical.”

Matías leaned forward slightly.

“What made it feel that way?”

Adrián thought for a moment.

“The people I guess.”

“In what sense?”

“They were... into it.”

“Into it, that doesn’t explain much.”

“I know.”

Adrián laughed.

“That’s the problem.”

Marcos stirred his coffee slowly.

“I visited one too.”

“Where?” Adrián asked.

“Different city.”

“And?”

Marcos shrugged.

“It was good.”

Elías raised an eyebrow.

“Well then...that clears everything up.”

Matías spoke next.

“I visited one as well.”

Adrián pointed at him.

“See? This is what I mean.”

“What.”

“We all travel. We all visit churches.”

“Yes.”

“And every time we come back saying the same thing.”

“What’s that?” Elías asked.

Adrián leaned forward slightly.

“I think it was good.”

Marcos smiled.

“That’s true.”

“But we never really explain why.”

“No,” Elías said.

They sat quietly for a moment while the sounds of the café moved around them. Cups clinked. Someone laughed near the door.

Adrián looked around the table.

“Let me ask something.”

Nobody answered yet.

“What actually makes a church healthy?”

Elías folded his hands.

“That depends what you mean by healthy.”

“Well, that’s my point. We all come back saying it was good. That isn’t much of a qualifier.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“If we really want to put a standard to it, we should base it on Scripture, not our own opinions.”

“Of course,” Adrián said.

“Because if you asked ten people you’d get ten different answers.”

“That’s true,” Marcos said.

Adrián stared into his coffee for a moment.

Then he looked back up.

“You know something I’ve been wondering?”

“What?” Marcos asked.

Adrián looked at the three of them.

“Lately I’ve been wondering, what exactly is a *carnal* church?”

Nobody answered.

The word hung there for a moment.

Matías frowned slightly.

Elías looked down at the table.

Marcos tapped his spoon gently against his cup.

Finally Elías spoke.

“You know,” he said slowly,

“I distinctly remember Paul using that word somewhere.”

Adrián looked at him.

“Carnal?”

“Yes.”

“Where?”

Elías thought for a moment.

“Corinth, I think.”

Adrián turned his cup slowly in his hands.

“That’s interesting, are you certain?”

“I recall recently hearing a message on it,” Elías said.

Matías spoke quietly.

“And as I understand it, Paul wasn’t talking about unbelievers.”

“No, you are correct” Elías said.

“He was talking about the church.”

Silence settled over the table.

Marcos finally spoke.

“If that’s true...”

He looked around at the others.

“Maybe you’re on to something Adrian, maybe we’ve been asking the wrong question.”

Adrián tilted his head.

“What do you mean?”

Marcos shrugged slightly.

“Maybe the question isn’t what a good church looks like.”

He paused.

“Maybe the question is this...”

He looked at the others.

“What does Scripture say a carnal church actually is?”

No one answered.

But now they all wanted to know.

Chapter 3

Why Corinth?



The coffee had cooled a little.

Adrián turned the cup slowly in his hands while the others sat quietly for a moment.

Finally he looked up.

“So... Corinth.”

Elías nodded.

“I think so.”

“You’re not sure?”

“I’m fairly sure,” Elías said. “But I’d have to see it.”

Marcos leaned back slightly.

“Why Corinth?”

Elías thought for a moment.

“I remember Paul saying something about believers being *car-nal*.”

Matías frowned.

“That’s a strong word.”

“Yes.”

“Are you sure he was talking about believers?”

“That’s what I remember.”

Adrián sat up a little.

“Well good sir, now I’m curious.”

Marcos looked at Elías.

“Do you remember where?”

Elías shook his head.

“Not exactly, first Corinthians probably”

“Oh, that narrows it down.”

Adrián laughed.

“It’s in there somewhere.”

Matías looked thoughtful.

“If Paul actually called a church carnal...”

He paused.

“That would be serious.”

“Yes,” Elías said quietly.

Marcos stirred his coffee again.

“But before we go chasing a word...”

He looked at the others.

“Maybe we should ask something first.”

“What.”

“What do we mean by carnal?”

Adrián pointed at him.

“Good question.”

“Everyone uses the word.”

“Yes.”

“But what does it actually mean?”

Matías answered first.

“Fleshly.”

Adrián smiled.

“Well that clears everything up.”

Matías ignored him.

“I mean controlled by the flesh.”

Elías nodded slightly.

“That would make sense.”

Marcos looked around the table.

“But how would you know?”

No one answered immediately.

Adrián finally said,

“I’ve heard people say it means worldly.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“That’s common.”

Matías added,

“Living in sin.”

Elías shook his head slightly.

“That seems too simple.”

“Why.”

“Because Paul was writing to churches.”

“So?”

“So if that’s all he meant,” Elías said, “then every church that struggles with sin would be carnal.”

Adrián leaned forward.

“That might actually be true.”

Marcos laughed softly.

“That would make things interesting.”

Matías looked uneasy.

“I doubt Paul meant it that loosely.”

“What do you think he meant?” Adrián asked.

Matías took a moment before answering.

“Maybe he meant believers who are not spiritually mature?”

Elías nodded slowly.

“That could be closer.”

Marcos looked back at Elías.

“But you said something else.”

“What.”

“That Paul actually used the word.”

“Yes,”

“Then maybe we should see what he meant instead of guessing.”

Adrián lifted his hands.

“I like that plan.”

“Of course you do.”

“Why wouldn’t I?”

“Because it might prove you wrong.”

Adrián grinned.

“That has never stopped me before.”

Matías leaned forward slightly.

“If we’re going to do that...”

He paused.

“Then we should actually read the passage.”

Elías nodded.

“Yes. Our answer needs to come from Scripture.”

Adrián looked around the table.

“Anyone have a Bible?”

Three hands went to their bags almost at the same time.

Marcos laughed.

“Well that was predictable.”

Elías opened his well-underlined Bible and flipped slowly through the worn pages.

“Let’s see.”

The others waited. E

The café noise hummed quietly around them.

Finally Elías stopped.

“Ok. 1 Corinthians. I remember seeing it here somewhere...”

“Where?” Adrián asked.

“First Corinthians 3.”

He turned the Bible so the others could see.

“Starting at verse 1.”

Matías leaned closer.

“What does it say?”

Elías read slowly.

“And I, brothers, could not speak to you as to spiritual men, but as to men of flesh, as to infants in Christ.”

Adrián sat back slightly.

“Wait.”

He pointed.

“Did he say *brothers*?”

“Yes.”

“So believers.”

“Yes.”

“But then he calls them fleshly.”

Matías looked at the page carefully.

“Keep reading.”

Elías continued.

“I gave you milk to drink, not solid food; for you were not yet able to receive it.”

Marcos nodded slowly.

“Immaturity.”

“Apparently.”

Elías kept reading.

“Indeed, even now you are not yet able, for you are still fleshly.”

Adrián whistled quietly.

“He said it twice.”

“Yes.”

Matías leaned closer.

“What comes next?”

Elías read again.

“For since there is jealousy and strife among you, are you not fleshly?”

Nobody spoke for a moment.

Finally Marcos said,

“So he tells us how he knows.”

“How.”

Marcos pointed to the page.

“Jealousy.”

“And strife,” Adrián added.

Matías frowned slightly.

“That seems... relational.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“Not immoral behavior exactly.”

“Not exactly,” Marcos said.

Adrián leaned back in his chair.

“So let me get this straight.”

He pointed toward the Bible.

“Paul is talking to believers.”

“Yes.”

“And he calls them fleshly.”

“Yes.”

“And the evidence is...”

He paused.

“Jealousy and strife.”

Elías nodded.

“That’s what it says.”

Matías sat quietly for a moment.

Finally he said,

“That’s... interesting.”

Adrián laughed.

“That’s one way to say it.”

Marcos tapped the table gently.

“If that’s the case...”

He looked at the others.

“Then carnality might not mean what we think it means.”

Elías closed the Bible slowly.

“Yes.”

“That’s what I’m starting to wonder.”

Adrián leaned forward again.

“Well now I have another question.”

“What?” said Elías while he opened his Bible up again.

Adrian looked around the table.

“What exactly is the *flesh*?”

This time no one answered.

And that bothered them more than they expected.

Chapter 4

What Is the Flesh?



For a few seconds no one spoke.

The café hummed quietly around them. Cups clinked somewhere behind the counter. Someone near the door laughed too loudly at something on their phone.

But at the table by the window the mood had shifted.

Adrián finally broke the silence.

“Well that’s awkward. Anybody want another coffee?”

Marcos looked at him.

“What’s awkward?”

“We just discovered we’ve all been using a word we apparently don’t understand.”

Matías leaned back slightly.

“I wouldn’t say we don’t understand it.”

Adrián smiled.

“Alrighty then.”

He gestured toward Matías.

“You go first.”

Matías hesitated.

“Define the flesh.”

Matías looked at the table for a moment before answering.

“The flesh is our sinful nature.”

“That’s what most people say,” Marcos said.

“Yes.”

“And?”

Matías shrugged slightly.

“It’s the part of us that wants to disobey God.”

Adrián nodded.

“That’s how I’ve heard it explained too.”

Elías had been quiet.

He spoke slowly.

“But that doesn’t quite fit what we just read.”

Matías looked at him.

“Why not?”

Elías tapped the open Bible gently.

“Paul didn’t mention immoral behavior.”

“That doesn’t mean it isn’t included.”

“No,” Elías said. “But that wasn’t the example he used.”

Marcos leaned forward slightly.

“He used jealousy.”

“And strife,” Adrián added still perplexed by the term.

“Yes,” Elías said.

“That’s relational conflict.”

Matías folded his arms.

“That’s still sin.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“But it’s not the kind of sin most people think about when they hear the word flesh.”

Adrián laughed quietly.

“That’s true.”

“What do people usually think of?” Marcos asked.

Adrián raised his eyebrows.

“Oh you know.”

“What.”

“The obvious stuff.”

Matías shook his head slightly.

“That’s part of the flesh.”

“But apparently not the only part,” Elías said.

Marcos looked thoughtful.

“So maybe the flesh is bigger than we think.”

Adrián pointed at him.

“That sounds dangerous.”

“Why?”

“Because if the definition gets bigger...”

He leaned back in his chair.

“More people get included.”

Marcos smiled.

“That might be the problem.”

Matías wasn’t smiling.

“The flesh is serious.”

“No one said it wasn’t,” Adrián said.

“But how do you define it?”

Matías thought for a moment.

“Human effort.”

The others looked at him confused.

“Explain,” Marcos said.

Matías spoke carefully.

“The flesh is when a person tries to live the Christian life by their own strength instead of depending on God.”

Elías nodded slowly.

“That’s closer.”

Adrián tilted his head.

“But hold on.”

“What.”

“If that’s true...”

He gestured toward the Bible.

“Then those people in Corinth weren’t trying too hard.”

Marcos laughed quietly.

“Interesting point. That’s true.”

Matías didn’t answer.

Elías spoke again.

“There might be something else here that we’re missing.”

“What.”

“The flesh might not just be immoral behavior.”

Marcos nodded.

“And it might not just be effort either.”

Adrián looked at him.

“Well that narrows it down.”

Marcos ignored him.

“Maybe the flesh is simply human life operating independently from God.”

Elías looked at him.

“That would explain a lot.”

Matías frowned slightly.

“But if that’s the case...”

He paused.

“Then the flesh could appear very different depending on the situation.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“In one place it might look like sin.”

“And in another place,” Marcos said,

“It might look like religion.”

Adrián leaned forward slowly.

“Now that’s interesting.”

The table went quiet again.

After a moment Adrián spoke.

“Let me tell you how I’ve always thought about it.”

The others waited.

“I figured the flesh meant the obvious stuff.”

“What obvious stuff?” Marcos asked.

“You know.”

Adrián waved his hand vaguely.

“Drinking too much. Sleeping around. That kind of thing.”

Matías nodded.

“That’s part of it.”

“Right.”

Adrián shrugged.

“So as long as I wasn’t doing those things...”

He grinned.

“I figured I was doing alright.”

Marcos smiled.

“That’s probably how most people think.”

“Yes,” Elías said quietly.

“But that doesn’t seem to be Paul’s definition.”

Matías leaned forward again.

“Then what is?”

Nobody answered immediately.

Finally Marcos said,

“If we’re serious about this...”

He pointed toward the Bible.

“Then maybe we should find out how Scripture uses the word.”

Adrián nodded slowly.

“I like that.”

Elías agreed.

“Yes. Definitely”

Matías looked thoughtful.

“How would we do that?”

Marcos shrugged.

“We could trace it.”

“Trace it?”

“You know, follow the word.”

“Where it appears?” Elías said.

“Yes.”

“And see what Scripture says about it.”

Adrián smiled.

“Well now.”

He lifted his cup again.

“This investigation is getting interesting.”

Matías wasn't smiling.

He was staring quietly at the open Bible.

Because something had begun to bother him.

If the flesh meant more than obvious sin...

Then avoiding obvious sin might not solve the problem at all.

And that thought was harder to ignore than he expected.

Chapter 5

Tracing the Flesh



The café looked the same as always.

Same tables.

Same smell of coffee.

Same quiet noise of people talking.

But the conversation at the table by the window felt different now.

The question from the previous week had stayed with them.

Adrián arrived first again.

He had already finished half his coffee by the time Elías walked in.

“You started without me.”

“I always start without you.”

Elías sat down.

“Well?”

“Well what?”

“You said you were going to look into it.”

Adrián nodded slowly.

“I did.”

“And?”

Adrián leaned back in his chair.

“I’m confused.”

Elías smiled slightly.

“That didn’t take long. Did you study it thoroughly?”

Adrián pointed at him.

“No, listen.”

He leaned forward again.

“I thought this was going to be simple.”

“What did you expect?”

“I expected to find a few verses about people doing bad things.”

“And?”

“And that’s not what I found.”

Elías waited.

“What did you find?”

Adrián rubbed the back of his neck.

“Honestly?”

“Yes.”

“I have more questions now than when we started.”

Just then Marcos arrived and sat down.

“More questions about what?”

Adrián pointed at him.

“Perfect timing.”

“What did I miss?”

“We’re talking about the flesh.”

Marcos nodded.

“Ah.”

“You looked into it too?”

“A little. I had a hard time sleeping last night.”

“And?”

Marcos shrugged.

“Same problem.”

Adrián pointed at him again.

“See?”

“What problem?”

“The word shows up in places I didn’t expect.”

Matías arrived a few minutes later and joined them.

“You started already.”

“Yes, we did in fact. Nice of you to join us.” Adrián said.

“Good.”

Matías sat down.

“What did you find?”

Adrián laughed quietly.

“That’s the problem.”

“What.”

“I’m not sure what I found.”

Elías leaned forward slightly.

“Start somewhere.”

Adrián nodded.

“Alright.”

He reached into his bag and pulled out a new Bible and a small notebook.

“I started by looking for the word flesh in the letters.”

“Paul’s letters?” Marcos asked.

“Yes.”

“And?”

Adrián flipped a few pages.

“The first thing I noticed is that Paul talks about the flesh a lot.”

“That doesn’t surprise me,” Matías said.

“Wait,” Adrián said.

“It gets stranger.”

“How.”

“In some places it clearly refers to sinful behavior.”

“That’s what we expected,” Marcos said.

“Yes.”

“But in other places...”

He looked up.

“It doesn’t.”

The others waited.

Elías finally said,

“Give an example.”

Adrián flipped another page.

“Galatians.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“That makes sense.”

“Yes,” Adrián said.

“But listen to this.”

He turned the notebook toward them.

“Paul says something strange.”

“What.”

Adrián read slowly.

“Having begun by the Spirit, are you now being perfected by the flesh?”

Matías frowned immediately.

“That’s Galatians 3.”

“Yes.”

“What’s strange about that?” Marcos asked.

Adrián looked up.

“Think about it.”

“They began by the Spirit.”

“Yes.”

“But now they’re trying to finish by the flesh.”

“Yes.”

Matías spoke quietly.

“That sounds like effort.”

“Yes,” Adrián said.

“Religious effort.”

The table went quiet.

Marcos tapped the table slowly.

“So the flesh might not just mean immoral behavior.”

“No,” Elías said.

“It might also mean relying on human strength.”

Matías frowned more deeply.

“That’s not necessarily wrong.”

“What.”

“Effort.”

Marcos looked at him.

“But Paul seems to be criticizing it.”

Matías didn’t answer immediately.

Adrián continued.

“That’s what confused me.”

He flipped another page.

“And then I saw something else.”

“What.”

“The works of the flesh.”

“Galatians 5,” Elías said.

“Yes.”

Adrián nodded.

“And some of them are exactly what we expected.”

“Like what?” Marcos asked.

“Immorality.”

“That fits.”

“Yes.”

“But then there are others.”

“What.”

Adrián looked down at the list.

“Jealousy.”

Marcos nodded.

“That matches Corinth.”

“Yes.”

Adrián continued.

“Strife.”

“Also Corinth.”

“Factions.”

Matías looked uncomfortable.

“That’s interesting.”

Adrián closed the notebook slowly.

“Do you see the problem?”

“What problem?” Marcos asked.

Adrián looked around the table.

“If jealousy and strife are works of the flesh...”

He paused.

“Then the problem in Corinth wasn’t just bad behavior.”

“No,” Elías said quietly.

“It was something deeper.”

Matías stared at the table.

“So the flesh might not always look immoral.”

“No,” Marcos said.

“And it might not always look religious either.”

Adrián leaned back again.

“That’s exactly why I said I’m confused.”

He looked at the others.

“I thought the flesh meant obvious sin.”

Matías spoke quietly.

“Isn’t it?”

Elías nodded slowly.

“But Scripture seems to be using the word differently.”

The table went silent again.

After a moment Adrián spoke.

“So now I have a question.”

“What.”

He looked around the table.

“If the flesh can look immoral...”

He paused.

“And it can also look religious...”

He leaned forward slightly.

“How would we recognize it?”

No one answered.

Because suddenly the investigation felt much closer to home than any of them expected.

Chapter 6

Religious Flesh



No one spoke for a while.

The noise of the café carried on around them like nothing unusual had happened. Someone at the next table was explaining a travel story with wide gestures. A spoon clinked against a cup somewhere behind them.

But at the table by the window the four men sat quietly. The sunlight was closer now to their table.

Adrián broke it first.

“Well.”

He looked around the table.

“That was not the direction I expected this to go.”

Marcos nodded.

“Same here.”

Matías leaned forward slightly.

“I’m not convinced yet. I think you’re making it more than what it needs to be.”

Adrián smiled.

“I was wondering when that was coming.”

Matías ignored him.

“Just because the word appears in different contexts doesn’t mean we understand it.”

“That’s true,” Elías said.

“We need to be careful.”

Marcos looked at Matías.

“What part bothers you?”

Matías didn't answer immediately.

Finally he said,

"This idea that the flesh could appear religious."

Adrián leaned forward.

"You don't think it can?"

"I think carnality is just that, carnality...you know, immorality. How can someone who is trying to do the right thing be wrong?"

Elías spoke quietly.

"But that's exactly what Galatians sounds like."

Matías looked at him.

"How."

Elías opened his Bible again and turned a few worn pages.

"Look at the situation."

The others leaned closer.

"These believers had begun with the Spirit."

"Yes," Marcos said.

"That's what Paul said."

"And now," Elías continued, "they were trying to be perfected by the flesh."

Matías nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

“But what were they actually doing?”

Adrián shrugged.

“Trying to obey God?”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“They were trying to keep the law.”

Marcos looked thoughtful.

“So they weren’t becoming immoral.”

“No.”

“They were becoming more serious.”

“Yes.”

Adrián leaned back.

“That’s interesting.”

Matías folded his arms.

“Trying to obey God is not a problem.”

“No,” Elías said.

“But in this case, Paul calls it flesh.”

The table went quiet again.

Adrián finally spoke.

“So let me see if I understand this.”

He looked at the open Bible.

“These believers started by trusting God.”

“Yes.”

“And then later...”

He gestured slightly.

“They started relying on their own effort.”

“That seems to be the problem,” Marcos said.

Matías frowned.

“But effort is part of discipline.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“But Paul isn’t criticizing discipline.”

“What then?”

“Dependence.”

Elías nodded.

“That’s the difference.”

Adrián pointed at the Bible.

“So the problem wasn’t that they wanted to obey God.”

“No.”

“The problem was how they were trying to do it.”

“Exactly,” Elías said.

Matías was quiet.

Finally he spoke.

“That’s a super dangerous idea.”

Adrián raised an eyebrow.

“Why?”

Matías answered slowly.

“Because if you tell people their effort is flesh...”

He paused.

“They might stop trying.”

Adrián laughed softly.

“I’ve heard that argument before.”

Marcos nodded.

“Most of us have.”

Elías spoke carefully.

“But that doesn’t change what the text says.”

Matías didn’t answer.

He was staring at the page.

Adrián leaned forward again.

“Let me ask something.”

“What,” Marcos said.

“If the Galatians were becoming more serious about religion...”

He paused.

“And Paul still calls it flesh...”

He looked around the table.

“Then what would that look like in a church today?”

No one answered right away.

Finally Marcos said,

“It might look very impressive.”

“How.”

“Very disciplined.”

“Very committed,” Elías added.

Matías spoke quietly.

“Very careful.”

Adrián nodded slowly.

“But underneath it...”

He pointed toward the Bible again.

“It would still be the flesh.”

The word hung in the air.

Matías finally looked up.

“That’s difficult to accept.”

“Why,” Adrián asked.

Matías took a long breath before answering.

“Because if that’s true...”

He paused.

“Then a church could look extremely serious about God...”

He looked back down at the page.

“And still be operating in the flesh.”

No one said anything.

Because they were beginning to realize something.

If that was true...

Then recognizing carnality might be much harder than any of them expected.

Chapter 7

The Works of the Flesh



The Bible was still open on the table.

No one had moved it. Now the sunlight was right on the Bible.

Adrián leaned forward again.

“So what else did you find?”

Elías turned a few pages slowly.

“There’s another passage that might help.”

“Where?”

“Same letter.”

“Galatians?”

“Yes.”

Marcos nodded.

“That makes sense.”

Elías stopped turning pages.

“Here.”

He looked down.

“Chapter five.”

Matías leaned closer. He noted the page was well underlined and certain words were highlighted in his NASB Bible.

“What does it say?”

Elías began reading.

“Now the works of the flesh are evident...”

Adrián interrupted.

“Wait.”

“What.”

“That sounds helpful.”

Marcos smiled.

“Yes.”

“If the works of the flesh are evident,” Adrián said, “then maybe this will finally clear things up.”

Elías continued reading.

“Immorality, impurity, sensuality...”

Matías nodded.

“That fits. That’s what I’ve always thought.”

“Yes,” Adrián said.

“That’s what we expected.”

Elías kept reading.

“Idolatry, sorcery...”

Marcos shrugged.

“Yes.”

Then Elías continued.

“Enmities...”

He paused.

Marcos looked up.

“Enmities?”

“Yes.”

Adrián leaned forward.

“What does that mean?”

“Hostility,” Elías said.

“Conflict between people.”

Adrián sat back.

“That’s different.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

He continued reading.

“Strife...”

Marcos nodded slowly.

“That word again.”

“Yes.”

“The same one we saw in Corinth.”

Elías nodded.

“Yes.”

Matías shifted slightly in his chair.

“Keep going.”

Elías read again.

“Jealousy...”

Adrián pointed at the page.

“That one too.”

Marcos looked thoughtful.

“Interesting.”

Elías continued.

“Outbursts of anger...”

Matías frowned.

“I’m not going to lie. I’ve seen that in church.”

Adrián laughed.

“Understatement.”

Elías kept reading.

“Disputes... dissensions... factions...”

The table went very quiet.

Marcos finally spoke.

“Factions?”

Adrián nodded slowly.

“That sounds familiar.”

Elías looked up from the page.

“Yes.”

Matías spoke quietly.

“That’s division.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“Groups forming against each other.”

Adrián leaned back.

“Well that’s uncomfortable.”

Marcos looked at the others.

“Look at the pattern.”

“What pattern?”

“These are relational fractures.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“People turning against each other.”

Matías was staring at the list.

“Jealousy.”

“Strife.”

“Factions.”

He shook his head slightly.

“That sounds just like Corinth.”

“Yes,” Adrián said.

“That’s what Paul said.”

Marcos tapped the table slowly.

“So the works of the flesh are not just personal sins.”

“No,” Elías said.

“They destroy relationships.”

Adrián leaned forward again.

“So let me see if I understand something.”

“What,” Marcos said.

“If jealousy and strife are works of the flesh...”

He paused.

“And factions are works of the flesh...”

He looked around the table.

“Then a church could be very active...”

“Yes.”

“Very organized...”

“Yes.”

“Very serious...”

“Uh huh.”

“And still be operating in the flesh.”

Matías didn’t answer.

He was still staring at the page. His stiffness was noticeable.

Finally he said quietly,

“That’s disturbing.”

Adrián nodded.

“It is.”

Marcos spoke next.

“But it also explains something.”

“What.”

“Why churches that look strong from the outside sometimes feel unhealthy inside.”

Elías nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

“Because the flesh doesn’t always appear immoral.”

“No,” Marcos said.

“Sometimes it appears structured.”

Adrián laughed softly.

“That’s even worse.”

Matías finally looked up.

“There’s something else.”

“What.”

Matías pointed at the passage.

“Paul says the works of the flesh are *evident*.”

“Yes.”

“What do you think he means by that?”

Marcos answered first.

“That you can see them.”

“Yes.”

“In relationships.”

Adrián leaned forward again.

“So the flesh reveals itself.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“How?”

“By what it produces.”

The four men sat quietly for a moment.

Then Adrián spoke again.

“So if we followed this idea...”

He paused.

“We might be able to diagnose a church.”

Marcos nodded slowly.

“How.”

“By its fruit.”

Matías looked thoughtful.

“If jealousy, strife, and factions appear...”

He finished the thought quietly.

“Then the flesh is activated.”

Elías closed the Bible gently.

“That seems to be what Paul is saying.”

Adrián looked around the table again.

“Well.”

He took a sip of his coffee, now cold.

“This investigation just became a lot more serious.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

Matías said nothing.

Because something about this passage had begun to bother him more deeply than the others realized.

If factions were works of the flesh...

Then some of the things he had always defended might not be as spiritual as he had believed.

And that thought was harder to ignore than he expected.

Chapter 8

By Their Fruit



The list was still sitting in front of them.

Jealousy.

Strife.

Factions.

The words felt heavier the longer they looked at them.

Adrián finally pushed his chair back a little.

“Well.”

He rubbed his face.

“That was cheerful.”

Marcos smiled faintly.

“It was honest.”

Matías was still staring at the passage.

“What bothers me,” he said slowly, “is how ordinary these things are.”

“What do you mean?” Adrián asked.

“They’re not shocking.”

“No,” Elías said.

“They’re common.”

Marcos nodded.

“Very common.”

Adrián leaned forward again.

“Which raises another problem.”

“What problem?” Marcos asked.

“If these things are works of the flesh...”

He tapped the page lightly.

“Then they probably appear in more churches than we’d like to admit.”

Matías frowned slightly.

“That doesn’t mean the whole church is carnal.”

“No,” Elías said.

“But it might reveal something about its condition.”

Marcos looked thoughtful.

“You know what this reminds me of?”

“What,” Adrián said.

“Something Jesus said.”

Elías nodded slowly.

“I was thinking the same thing.”

Adrián looked between them.

“Which thing.”

Marcos answered.

“You know a tree by its fruit.”

Adrián sat back.

“Oh.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“If the fruit appears...”

He paused.

“It tells you something about the tree.”

Matías leaned back slightly.

“Matthew 7 right?”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“Jesus said good trees produce good fruit.”

“And bad trees produce bad fruit,” Adrián finished.

Elías nodded.

“Yes.”

“I heard a guy say that was talking about knowing those who are true believers.” Matías said.

“that’s a common misconception” Elías said agreeing.

Adrián rubbed his chin.

“So if jealousy, strife, and factions are works of the flesh...”

He looked at the others.

“Then they are fruit.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“Fruit or works of the flesh.”

Marcos added,

“And fruit reveals the source.”

Matías looked thoughtful.

“So if those things appear repeatedly...”

He paused.

“They reveal what is feeding the church.”

Adrián laughed softly.

“That’s uncomfortable.”

“Why,” Marcos asked.

“Because most churches would never say they operate by the flesh.”

“No,” Elías said.

“But the fruit might say otherwise.”

Matías spoke slowly.

“There’s something else about fruit.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

“It doesn’t appear overnight.”

“No,” Elías said.

“It grows over time.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“Fruit is the result of something being cultivated.”

The four men sat quietly for a moment.

Adrián finally spoke.

“So let me see if I understand this.”

He pointed toward the Bible.

“If we want to know whether a church is operating by the flesh...”

He paused.

“We could look at the fruit?”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“What kind of relationships exist.”

“Yes.”

“How people treat each other.”

“Yes.”

Marcos nodded.

“And whether jealousy and factions appear.”

Adrián leaned back slowly.

“Well.”

He looked around the table.

“That would make diagnosing a church possible.”

Matías raised an eyebrow.

“Diagnosing?”

“Yes.”

“Like a doctor?”

“Exactly.”

Marcos smiled.

“That’s not a bad comparison.”

Elías nodded.

“Scripture describes the condition.”

“And the fruit reveals it,” Marcos added.

Matías looked down at the table.

“That’s serious.”

Adrián tilted his head.

“Why?”

Matías answered quietly.

“Because if we applied that principle honestly...”

He paused.

“I’m not going to lie...We may discover things we don’t want to see.”

No one answered.

Because they were all thinking the same thing.

Adrián finally broke the silence.

“Well sir.”

He lifted his cup again.

“If we’re going to do this...”

He looked around the table.

“We might as well do it properly.”

Marcos nodded.

“How?”

Adrián smiled.

“Let’s start paying attention.”

“To what?” Elías asked.

“The fruit.”

The word hung in the air.

Because if fruit reveals the source...

Then the condition of a church might not be hidden nearly as well as people imagine.

Chapter 9

Diagnosing a Church



The Bible was closed now.

Not because they were finished with it.

But because none of them were quite sure what to say next. The sunlight had moved to the far corner of the café.

Adrián finally broke the silence.

“So if fruit reveals the source...”

He looked around the table.

“Then a church should be diagnosable.”

Marcos nodded.

“That seems logical.”

Elías leaned back slightly.

“Like a physician.”

“What do you mean?” Adrián asked.

“A doctor doesn’t guess about a disease.”

“No.”

“He looks at symptoms.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“And the symptoms reveal the condition.”

“Yes.”

Adrián smiled.

“Well then.”

He spread his hands slightly.

“What would the symptoms of a carnal church be?”

Marcos answered first.

“Jealousy.”

“Strife,” Elías added.

“Factions,” Adrián said.

Matías was quiet.

Those words had begun to feel uncomfortably familiar.

Marcos spoke again.

“You know something strange?”

“What,” Adrián said.

“The church I visited last week...”

He paused.

“I think I actually saw some of that.”

Adrián looked at him.

“What do you mean?”

Marcos shrugged slightly.

“Nothing dramatic.”

“But?”

“There were small groups forming.”

“Groups?”

“Yes.”

“Different camps.”

Elías nodded slowly.

“That sounds familiar.”

“Does it,” Adrián said.

“Yes.”

“Where?”

Elías leaned forward slightly.

“In Corinth.”

The table went quiet again.

Adrián smiled.

“You think that church was like Corinth?”

“I’m not saying that,” Elías said.

“I’m saying the fruit sounds similar.”

Matías spoke quietly.

“That’s super dangerous.”

“Why?”

“Because once you start diagnosing churches...”

He paused.

“You might discover things you don’t want to discover.”

Adrián laughed softly.

“I think we already did.”

Marcos leaned forward again.

“Actually...”

He looked around the table.

“This might explain something else.”

“What,” Adrián said.

“The church I visited actually looked very healthy.”

“How?”

“Large.”

“Active.”

“Lots of ministries.”

“That sounds good,” Adrián said.

“Yes.”

“But underneath it...”

He hesitated.

“There was tension.”

Elías nodded slowly.

“Corinth looked impressive too.”

“That’s true,” Adrián said.

“They had gifts.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“Many gifts.”

Matías spoke quietly.

“And yet Paul called them carnal.”

“Yes.”

Adrián leaned back.

“That’s uncomfortable.”

“Why,” Marcos asked.

“Because it means a church can look impressive...”

He pointed at the table.

“And still be operating by the flesh.”

Matías looked down again.

“Man, that’s exactly what Paul said.”

Elías spoke carefully.

“So maybe we should do something.”

“What?”

Marcos answered.

“We should compare.”

“Compare what?” Adrián asked.

“The churches we visited.”

“With what?”

“With the churches in Scripture.”

Adrián smiled slowly.

“Well sir, now that...”

He lifted his cup again.

“That sounds like an investigation.”

Matías looked uneasy.

“But we need to be careful.”

“Why,” Marcos asked.

“Because diagnosing churches is not a small thing.”

“No,” Elías said.

“But ignoring Scripture would be worse.”

No one disagreed.

Adrián finally spoke.

“Well sir.”

He looked around the table.

“Let’s start with the obvious one.”

“What,” Marcos asked.

Adrián smiled.

“The church that reminded you of Corinth.”

Marcos shook his head.

“Not yet.”

“Why not?”

“Because I think you visited one first.”

Adrián laughed.

“That’s true.”

“And you said it felt...”

Marcos paused.

“Alive.”

Adrián nodded.

“Yes.”

“Well then,” Marcos said.

“Maybe we should start there.”

Adrián leaned back slowly.

“You want to hear about that church?”

“Yes.”

All three of them nodded.

Adrián took a slow sip of his coffee.

“Alright.”

He smiled slightly.

“Let me tell you what I saw.”

Chapter 10

The Lively Church

Adrián leaned back in his chair and folded his arms.

“You’re going to regret asking me to describe it.”

Marcos smiled.

“Why?”

“Because I liked it.”

“That’s allowed.”

Adrián shook his head.

“Not if this turns into a theological interrogation.”

Elías smiled slightly.

“Just tell us what you saw.”

Adrián nodded.

“Alright.”

He leaned forward.

“So I arrived about ten minutes before the service started.”

“Large building?” Marcos asked.

“Yes. Very. Well lit, modern.”

“Full?”

“Almost.”

Adrián laughed softly.

“Actually it filled up fast.”

He continued.

“People were greeting each other everywhere. Hugging. Laughing. Kids running around.”

“That sounds healthy,” Marcos said.

“It did.”

Matías nodded slightly.

“And the service?”

Adrián smiled.

“It started loud.”

“Loud?”

“Yes.”

“The music.”

Marcos nodded.

“Band?”

“Yes.”

“Good band?”

“Very.”

Adrián laughed.

“Actually impressive. They were good.”

He continued describing it.

“People were singing with their hands raised. Some had their eyes closed. Others were clapping.”

He shrugged.

“You could tell they meant it.”

Elías listened quietly.

“And the atmosphere?”

Adrián thought for a moment.

“Warm.”

“Very warm.”

“People seemed genuinely happy to be there.”

“That’s good,” Marcos said.

“Yes.”

Adrián nodded.

“Then something interesting happened.”

“What.”

“People began sharing things.”

“What kind of things?” Elías asked.

“Verses.”

“Encouragement.”

“Prayers.”

“Someone even stood up and said they felt God had given them something to share.”

Matías raised an eyebrow.

“And how did the church respond to that?”

“They listened.”

“No chaos?”

“No.”

“It felt... free.”

Adrián paused for a moment.

“There was also food afterward.”

Marcos smiled.

“That always helps.”

Adrián laughed.

“Yes.”

“Tables everywhere.”

“People talking.”

“Kids playing.”

“It felt like a family gathering.”

Elías asked quietly,

“And the teaching?”

Adrián nodded.

“There was a short message.”

“Short?”

“Yes.”

“But it was good.”

“How.”

“Encouraging.”

“In what sense?”

Adrián shrugged.

“The speaker talked about trusting God.”

“Living by faith.”

“Depending on the Spirit.”

“That sounds biblical,” Elías said.

“Yes.”

“That’s why I liked it.”

Adrián leaned back again.

“I walked out of there thinking...”

He paused.

“That felt good.”

Marcos nodded slowly.

“And you would go back?”

“Absolutely.”

Elías spoke quietly.

“What made it feel alive to you?”

Adrián didn’t hesitate.

“The people.”

“They weren’t stiff.”

“They weren’t afraid.”

“They were engaged.”

“It felt real.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“That’s not a bad thing.”

“No,” Adrián said.

“It really wasn’t.”

For a moment the others sat quietly.

Marcos finally spoke.

“You know something.”

“What.”

“That description reminds me of something.”

Adrián smiled.

“What.”

Marcos looked at Elías.

Elías nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

Adrián looked between them.

“What are you two thinking?”

Elías reached for the Bible again.

“There was another church that sounded like that.”

“Which one?”

Elías turned a few pages.

“Corinth.”

Adrián laughed softly.

“Really? Why?”

“Well.”

Marcos nodded.

“They were lively too.”

Adrián leaned forward.

“Hold on.”

“What.”

“You’re not about to ruin my story, are you?”

Elías smiled faintly.

“Let’s just read it.”

Adrián shook his head with a grin.

“I knew this was coming.”

Matías leaned forward again.

“What does Paul say about Corinth?”

Elías opened the Bible.

“Quite a lot.”

Adrián lifted his cup again.

“Well sir.”

He smiled.

“Let’s hear it.”

Chapter 11

The Corinth Question



Elías rested his hand on the open Bible.

Adrián watched him with a suspicious smile.

“You look too calm,” Adrián said.

“Why?”

“That’s the face you make right before you ruin something.”

Marcos laughed quietly.

“He might.”

Matías leaned forward.

“Let’s just read it.”

Elías nodded.

“Alright.”

He turned a few pages carefully.

“First Corinthians.”

Adrián leaned forward.

“So what exactly was going on in Corinth?”

Elías began reading slowly.

“Now concerning spiritual gifts, brethren, I do not
want you to be unaware...”

Adrián sat up.

“Wait.”

“What.”

“Spiritual gifts?”

“Yes.”

Adrián smiled.

“Well that already sounds familiar.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

Elías continued reading portions of the letter, moving through several passages.

Paul describing the gifts.

Prophecy.

Tongues.

Knowledge.

Healing.

Adrián shook his head slightly.

“They had everything.”

“That’s what it sounds like,” Marcos said.

Elías turned another page.

“And listen to this.”

He read again.

“You are not lacking in any gift...”

Adrián leaned back slowly.

“That sounds exactly like the church I visited.”

Matías nodded thoughtfully.

“A gifted church.”

“Yes.”

Elías looked up.

“But Paul still corrects them.”

“For what,” Adrián asked.

Elías flipped back a few pages.

“This.”

He pointed to the passage they had read earlier.

“For since there is jealousy and strife among you,
are you not fleshly?”

No one spoke. You could have heard someone sip their coffee
from across the room.

Adrián finally said,

“That’s the same passage we looked at.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“But now we’re seeing the context.”

Marcos leaned forward.

“They had gifts.”

“Yes.”

“They had activity.”

“Uh huh.”

“They had people speaking.”

“Yes.”

“And yet Paul still calls them carnal.”

“Yes.”

Adrián rubbed his chin.

“That’s strange.”

“Why,” Marcos asked.

“Because when we think of a carnal church...”

He paused.

“We usually imagine the opposite.”

“What do you mean,” Matías said.

“A cold church.”

“A lifeless church.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“But Corinth wasn’t cold.”

“No,” Elías said.

“They were energetic.”

“Very.”

Adrián looked thoughtful.

“So a church can look very alive...”

He gestured toward the Bible.

“And still be carnal?”

Matías spoke quietly.

“That seems to be exactly what Paul is saying.”

Elías nodded.

“Yes.”

Marcos leaned back.

“That’s important.”

“Why,” Adrián asked.

“Because it means activity alone proves nothing.”

Adrián smiled slightly.

“That might disappoint a lot of people.”

Matías looked serious.

“It should make us careful.”

Elías turned another page.

“There’s something else here.”

“What,” Marcos asked.

Elías read again.

“Each one of you is saying, ‘I am of Paul,’ and ‘I of Apollos,’ and ‘I of Cephas.’”

Adrián looked confused.

“What does that mean?”

Marcos answered.

“Groups.”

“Different camps forming.”

Matías nodded.

“Factions?”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“The very thing Galatians called a work of the flesh.”

Adrián leaned back again.

“So the fruit matches.”

“Yes.”

“The same fruit.”

Matías was quiet again.

Finally he said,

“That means something.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

Matías spoke slowly.

“It means carnality isn’t measured by how active a church is.”

“No,” Elías said.

“Or how gifted it is,” Marcos added.

Adrián finished the thought.

“It’s measured by the fruit.”

The table fell quiet again.

After a moment Adrián spoke softly.

“That’s uncomfortable.”

“Why,” Marcos asked.

“Because the church I visited felt great.”

He shrugged.

“And it might still be.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“But feeling alive isn’t the same as being spiritual.”

Adrián laughed quietly.

“That’s a line right there.”

Matías leaned forward again.

“So if Corinth looked lively...”

“And still had jealousy and factions...”

He paused.

“Then recognizing carnality might be harder than we thought.”

No one disagreed.

Adrián finally lifted his cup again.

“Well sir.”

He smiled faintly.

“This investigation is starting to ruin my favorite churches.”

Marcos laughed.

“That might be the point.”

Elías closed the Bible slowly.

“Yes.”

Because if Corinth could look alive and still be carnal...

Then perhaps the real question was not which churches were

lively.

But which churches were truly spiritual.

And that question had only just begun to unfold.

Chapter 12

The Divided Church



Elías had not moved the Bible.

It was still open in front of him.

Adrián leaned forward again.

“Keep going.”

“What.”

“Corinth.”

“You want more?”

“Yes.”

“If we’re going to compare it to churches we’ve seen...”

He gestured toward the Bible.

“We should probably see the whole picture.”

Elías nodded.

“That’s fair.”

He flipped back a page.

“Let’s start earlier.”

“Earlier?” Marcos asked.

“Yes.”

“This is near the beginning of the letter.”

He read slowly.

“Now I exhort you, brethren, by the name of our
Lord Jesus Christ, that you all agree...”

Matías nodded.

“That sounds good.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“But listen to the rest.”

He continued reading.

“That there be no divisions among you...”

Adrián sat up.

“Divisions.”

“Yes.”

Elías continued.

“But that you be made complete in the same mind
and the same judgment.”

Marcos leaned forward slightly.

“Why would Paul say that unless there were divisions?”

“Exactly,” Elías said.

He read the next line.

“For I have been informed concerning you, my brethren,
that there are quarrels among you.”

Adrián laughed softly.

“Well that escalated quickly.”

Matías frowned.

“Quarrels.”

“Yes.”

Elías kept reading.

“Now I mean this, that each one of you is saying,
‘I am of Paul,’ and ‘I of Apollos,’ and ‘I of Cephas,’
and ‘I of Christ.’”

Marcos nodded slowly.

“There it is.”

“What?” Adrián said.

“Factions.”

Matías nodded.

“Groups forming around leaders.”

“Yes.”

Adrián leaned back.

“That sounds... familiar.”

Marcos smiled slightly.

“It should.”

Elías closed the Bible for a moment.

“Think about what’s happening.”

“What.”

“These believers are organizing themselves around different teachers.”

Adrián shrugged.

“Is that necessarily wrong?”

Matías answered.

“It becomes wrong when it divides the church.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

Marcos added,

“When loyalty to a leader becomes stronger than unity in Christ.”

Adrián rubbed his chin.

“That happens more than people admit.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

Marcos leaned back.

“You know something.”

“What,” Adrián said.

“We usually think of division as a personality problem.”

“What do you mean?”

“People just not getting along.”

“Yes.”

“But Paul calls it something else.”

“What.”

Elías answered quietly.

“Flesh.”

The word landed heavily.

Adrián looked at the Bible again.

“So division...”

He paused.

“...is evidence of carnality.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

Matías spoke slowly.

“That changes things.”

“How.”

“If jealousy, strife, and factions are works of the flesh...”

He pointed at the table.

“Then division in a church is not a small issue.”

“No,” Marcos said.

“It reveals the source.”

Adrián leaned forward again.

“So let me see if I understand this.”

“What,” Marcos said.

“If we walked into a church and saw groups competing...”

“Yes.”

“People aligning with different leaders...”

“Yes.”

“Tension under the surface...”

“Yes.”

Adrián looked around the table.

“That might be evidence of the flesh.”

Elías nodded.

“That’s what Paul is saying.”

Matías looked thoughtful.

“And the church in Corinth still had gifts.”

“Yes.”

“And activity.”

“Yes.”

“And excitement.”

“Yes.”

Adrián shook his head slowly.

“So none of those things proved they were spiritual.”

“No,” Marcos said.

“They only proved they were active.”

The table went quiet again.

Finally Adrián said,

“Well sir. You know what this means.”

“What,” Elías asked.

“It means a church might look very impressive...”

He gestured slightly.

“...while something much deeper is wrong.”

Matías spoke quietly.

“Yes.”

“And that problem might not be visible immediately.”

Marcos nodded.

“But the fruit will eventually reveal it.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“Well sir.”

He took another sip of coffee.

“I think I’m starting to understand why Paul called them carnal.”

Elías reopened the Bible.

“Yes.”

“But we’ve only looked at one church so far.”

Marcos nodded.

“That’s true.”

Matías leaned forward slightly.

“What do you mean?”

Marcos answered.

“We should probably compare the others.”

“The others?”

“Yes.”

He looked around the table.

“The churches we visited.”

Adrián smiled slowly.

“That sounds interesting but dangerous.”

“Why.”

“Because if this investigation keeps going...”

He paused.

“...we might start recognizing more of these patterns.”

Elías closed the Bible again.

“Yes.”

“...to be honest, that might be exactly what we need to see.”

Chapter 13

The Serious Church



The conversation slowed after that.

Not because they had run out of things to say.

But because what they had already discovered was beginning to settle in.

Adrián finally looked at Matías.

“You said you visited a church too.”

Matías nodded.

“Yes.”

“Well?”

“Well what?”

“Your turn.”

Matías hesitated.

“Honestly, I’m not sure it’s relevant.”

Adrián smiled.

“That’s exactly what I said.”

Marcos nodded.

“Tell us about it Matías.”

Matías leaned back slightly, thinking.

“It was different to Adrián’s.”

“How,” Elías asked.

“Very serious.”

Adrián laughed softly.

“That doesn’t narrow it down. You mean dead?”

“No,” Matías said quietly.

“I mean very serious.”

Marcos leaned forward slightly.

“In what sense?”

Matías spoke slowly.

“The people were disciplined.”

“That is good good,” Marcos said.

“Yes.”

“The service was orderly.”

“That’s also good.”

“Yes.”

“There was a strong emphasis on obedience.”

Elías nodded.

“Still sounds good...what about the scriptures?”

Matías continued.

“They talked a lot about holiness.”

“That’s definitely good,” Adrián said.

“Yes.”

“But I can’t lie, the atmosphere felt...”

He paused.

“Heavy.”

Marcos tilted his head.

“Explain.”

Matías thought for a moment.

“It felt like everyone was trying very hard.”

“Trying how?” Elías asked.

“To live up to something.”

Adrián smiled.

“That sounds like church.”

Matías didn’t smile.

“It felt more intense than that.”

“How so?” Marcos asked.

“There was constant talk about discipline.”

“Daily devotions.”

“Accountability.”

“Guarding your life carefully.”

Adrián nodded slowly.

“That sounds very committed.”

“Yes.”

“No one seemed casual about their faith.”

“That’s admirable,” Elías said.

“Yes,” Matías replied.

“But there was also something else.”

“What,” Marcos asked.

Matías took a moment before answering.

“Pressure.”

The others looked at him.

“Pressure?”

“Yes.”

“To measure up.”

Adrián frowned slightly.

“To what?”

“To the standard.”

“What standard?”

Matías shrugged slightly.

“Holiness.”

Elías spoke quietly.

“Was Scripture being taught?”

“Yes.”

“Very directly.”

“Then what felt wrong?” Adrián asked.

Matías hesitated again.

“I’m not sure anything was wrong. I got the feeling I was the guilty one.”

The table went quiet.

Marcos spoke first.

“Sometimes things feel wrong before we know why.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

Adrián leaned forward.

“What kind of teaching was emphasized?”

Matías answered.

“Obedience.”

“Self-discipline.”

“Guarding your life carefully.”

“That doesn’t sound unbiblical,” Marcos said.

“No,” Matías said.

“But the message seemed to return to the same point every time.”

“What point?” Elías asked.

“That the Christian life requires constant effort.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“That’s not exactly shocking.”

“No,” Matías said.

“But it felt like something else was missing.”

“What.”

Matías looked down at the table.

“I’m not sure. Like I say, I couldn’t pin-point what it was. ”

The others waited.

Finally Marcos asked,

“How did people relate to each other?”

Matías thought about it.

“They were polite.”

“Respectful. I liked it.”

“But...”

“But what?” Adrián asked.

“There was distance.”

“Distance?”

“Yes.”

“It felt like everyone was watching themselves.”

“Watching themselves?” Elías said.

“Yes.”

“Careful not to fail.”

The table was quiet again.

Adrián finally said,

“That sounds exhausting.”

Matías didn’t respond.

Marcos leaned forward slightly.

“This reminds me of a...”

“What,” Adrián interrupted.

“The church in Galatia.”

Matías looked up.

“Why?”

Marcos answered.

“Because Paul said they began by the Spirit...”

He paused.

“...but were trying to finish by the flesh.”

Elías nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

Adrián looked between them.

“Are you saying a church could become very serious about obedience...”

He gestured toward Matías.

“...and still be operating by the flesh?”

Elías spoke carefully.

“That’s exactly what Paul said about Galatia.”

Matías sat quietly.

After a long silence, he spoke.

“That’s difficult to accept.”

“Why,” Adrián asked.

Matías answered slowly.

“Because if effort can be flesh...”

He paused.

“Then the problem might be much closer than we think.”

No one answered.

Because each of them had just realized something.

Carnality might not only appear in lively churches like Corinth.

It might also appear in churches that were extremely serious about doing what was right.

And that possibility made the investigation far more personal than any of them expected.

Chapter 14

The Correct Church



The conversation slowed again.

Three very different pictures of church life were now sitting on the table.

A lively church.

A serious church.

And a letter from Paul describing a divided church full of gifts.

Adrián finally looked at Elías.

“You’ve been very quiet.”

Elías smiled faintly.

“I’ve been listening.”

“That’s suspicious.”

Marcos laughed softly.

“Why?”

“Because when Elías gets quiet it usually means he’s thinking about a passage somewhere.”

Elías didn’t deny it.

“Actually,” he said, “there is one.”

Adrián leaned forward.

“Ha ha, of course there is.”

“Where?”

“Revelation.”

Matías looked up.

“The letters to the churches?”

“Yes.”

Marcos nodded slowly.

“That could be helpful.”

Elías opened the Bible again and turned a few pages.

“This one has always interested me.”

“Which one?” Adrián asked.

“The message to the church at Ephesus.”

Matías leaned closer.

“That was a strong church.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“Very strong.”

Adrián smiled.

“Well that’s refreshing.”

“Why.”

“Because so far every church we’ve looked at has been a mess.”

Elías began reading.

“I know your deeds and your toil and perseverance...”

Matías nodded.

“That’s good.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

He continued.

“That you cannot tolerate evil men...”

Adrián leaned forward slightly.

“That’s also good.”

“Yes.”

Elías kept reading.

“You put to the test those who call themselves apostles, and they are not...”

Marcos nodded.

“They tested doctrine.”

“Yes.”

Elías read again.

“You have perseverance and have endured for My name’s sake...”

Adrián sat back.

“Now that sounds like a solid church.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

“They were careful.”

“Very careful.”

Elías continued reading.

“And you have not grown weary.”

Marcos looked impressed.

“That’s remarkable. This is an exemplary church for us to model after.”

“Yes, but there’s more” Elías said quietly.

The others waited quietly.

Because they knew the passage wasn’t finished.

Elías read the next line slowly.

“But I have this against you...”

The words settled over the table.

Adrián frowned slightly.

“Well sir. That changed quickly.”

Matías leaned forward.

“What was the problem they faced?”

Elías read again.

“You have left your first love.”

No one spoke.

Adrián finally said,

“Ok. I didn’t see that coming.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“With everything else they were doing right.”

“Yes.”

Marcos leaned back in his chair.

“So the church was doctrinally careful.”

“Yes.”

“Morally serious.”

“Yes.”

“Disciplined.”

“Yes.”

“And yet Christ still rebukes them.”

“Yes.”

Adrián rubbed his chin.

“So let me understand something.”

“What,” Marcos said.

“Correct doctrine didn’t prevent the problem.”

“No,” Elías said quietly.

Matías spoke slowly.

“Doctrine is essential.”

“Of course,” Elías replied.

“No one is questioning that.”

Marcos nodded.

“But this passage shows something important.”

“What?”

“Correct doctrine alone does not guarantee spiritual life.”

Adrián leaned back.

“I’m sensing a little discomfort.”

“Why?” Matías asked.

“Because a lot of churches measure health by how correct their teaching is.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“But Ephesus had correct teaching.”

Matías looked at the passage again.

“They even tested false apostles.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“They were careful.”

“And yet something had still gone wrong.”

Adrián looked thoughtful.

“What exactly does it mean that they left their first love?”

Elías answered slowly.

“It means their devotion to Christ had grown cold.”

“But their doctrine hadn’t, that’s more important right?” Marcos said.

“I think so.”

Matías sat quietly.

Finally he said,

“That’s subtle.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“Very subtle.”

Adrián leaned forward again.

“So a church can...”

He paused.

“...teach the truth.”

“Yes.”

“Defend the truth.”

“Yes.”

“Protect the truth.”

“Yes.”

“And still lose something essential.”

The others nodded.

Marcos spoke quietly.

“That might be the most dangerous situation we’ve seen yet.”

“Why?” Adrián asked.

“Because everything looks so right.”

Elías closed the Bible slowly.

“Yes.”

“That’s exactly why Christ warned them.”

Matías spoke quietly.

“What did He tell them to do?”

Elías answered.

“Remember where they had fallen from.”

“And return.”

The table sat quietly again.

After a moment Adrián said,

“So now we’ve seen three different kinds of churches.”

“What do you mean,” Marcos asked.

“A lively church like Corinth.”

“Yes.”

“A serious church like Galatia.”

“Yes.”

“And a correct church like Ephesus.”

Matías added quietly,

“And each of them still had a problem.”

Adrián nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

“And that makes me wonder something.”

“What,” Elías asked.

Adrián looked around the table.

“What would a church look like...”

He paused.

“...that Christ actually approves?”

No one answered.

Because the investigation had now revealed something none of

them had expected.

Carnality could appear in excitement.

Carnality could appear in religious effort.

And apparently...

Carnality could even appear in doctrinal correctness.

And if that was true...

Then recognizing a truly spiritual church might be far harder than they had ever imagined.

Chapter 15

The Successful Church

For a while the table was quiet.

Not uncomfortable.

Just thoughtful.

They had now looked at three churches.

Three very different kinds of churches.

And yet all three had received correction in Scripture.

Adrián finally broke the silence.

“Well,” he said, “if we’re being fair...”

He looked across the table.

“...we should probably look at the last one.”

Marcos nodded slowly.

“You mean Laodicea.”

“Yes.”

Matías leaned back slightly.

“That one seems pretty straight forward.”

Adrián smiled.

“That’s what everyone says.”

Marcos opened the Bible and found the passage.

Revelation 3.

He read aloud.

“To the angel of the church in Laodicea write...”

Adrián leaned forward.

“Let’s hear it.”

Marcos continued.

“I know your deeds...”

Matías nodded.

“So they were active.”

“Yes.”

Marcos read the next line.

“That you are neither cold nor hot...”

Adrián frowned slightly.

“That’s the famous part.”

“Yes.”

Marcos continued.

“Because you are lukewarm, and neither hot nor cold, I will spit you out of My mouth.”

Adrián sat back.

“That’s strong.”

“Yes,” Elías said quietly.

Matías spoke slowly.

“I’ve always heard that explained as spiritual apathy.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“That’s the usual explanation.”

Adrián rubbed his chin.

“But the passage keeps going.”

Marcos nodded and continued reading.

“Because you say, ‘I am rich, and have become wealthy,
and have need of nothing.’”

Adrián laughed softly.

“Well sir. That sounds confident.”

“Yes.”

Marcos finished the sentence.

“And you do not know that you are wretched and
miserable and poor and blind and naked.”

The words settled over the table.

Adrián finally said,

“That’s quite a difference.”

Matías nodded.

“They were certain they were doing well.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“But Christ said the opposite.”

Marcos closed the Bible slightly.

“What interests me is what they believed about themselves.”

“What do you mean,” Adrián asked.

“They said they needed nothing.”

Matías thought about that.

“That suggests success.”

“Yes.”

Adrián leaned forward.

“Successful churches are usually admired.”

Marcos nodded.

“Large attendance.”

“Many programs.”

“Active ministries.”

Matías added,

“Financial stability.”

Elías spoke quietly.

“And influence.”

Adrián smiled.

“That sounds like the kind of church everyone wants.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“But apparently Christ saw something different.”

Matías asked the obvious question.

“What exactly was the problem?”

Marcos looked back at the passage.

“They believed they were spiritually rich.”

“But they weren’t,” Adrián said.

“Exactly.”

Elías spoke slowly.

“Actually, that may be the most dangerous condition yet.”

Adrián tilted his head.

“Why?”

“Because they were completely unaware.”

Matías nodded.

“They didn’t feel needy.”

“They felt successful.”

Adrián thought about that.

“So Corinth had visible problems.”

“Yes.”

“Galatia had doctrinal confusion.”

“Yes.”

“Ephesus had lost love.”

“Yes.”

“But Laodicea...”

He paused.

“...didn’t even know anything was wrong.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

Elías spoke carefully.

“That may be why Christ spoke so directly to them.”

Adrián looked at the passage again.

“What did He tell them to do?”

Marcos answered.

“He told them to buy gold refined by fire.”

“White garments.”

“And eye salve.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“So they needed something they didn’t realize they lacked.”

“Yes.”

Adrián leaned back.

“That’s unsettling.”

“Why,” Elías asked.

“Because it means a church can look strong...”

He paused.

“...and still be spiritually empty.”

The table sat quietly again.

Finally Matías spoke.

“So now we’ve seen four.”

Adrián nodded.

“Yes.”

“Corinth.”

“Galatia.”

“Ephesus.”

“Laodicea.”

Marcos spoke slowly.

“And all four had something in common.”

Adrián raised an eyebrow.

“What?”

Marcos looked around the table.

“Christ rebuked them.”

Elías nodded.

“Yes.”

Matías looked thoughtful.

“That means something important.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

“That carnality...”

He paused.

“...does not always look the same.”

Adrián nodded slowly.

“No.”

“Sometimes it looks exciting.”

“Sometimes it looks serious.”

“Sometimes it looks correct.”

“And sometimes...”

He gestured slightly.

“...it looks successful.”

The table went quiet again...the espresso machine could be heard

steaming in the background...

Because something had now become unavoidable.

Carnality could wear many different masks.

And if that was true...

Recognizing it might be far harder than anyone expected.

Adrián finally said what all of them were thinking.

“So let me ask the obvious question.”

The others looked at him.

“If all four of these churches were carnal in different ways...”

He paused.

“...what exactly is carnality?”

No one answered immediately.

Because that question was about to change the entire direction of their investigation.

Chapter 16

What Do We Mean by “Flesh”?



For a while no one spoke.

Four churches.

Four very different pictures.

Corinth.

Galatia.

Ephesus.

Laodicea.

Each one different.

Yet each one corrected.

Adrián finally broke the silence.

“So now what?”

Marcos looked at him.

“What do you mean?”

“I mean we’ve been talking about these churches like we understand the problem.”

Matías nodded.

“Carnality.”

“Yes,” Adrián said.

“That word keeps coming up.”

Elías folded his hands on the table.

“It does.”

Adrián leaned forward slightly.

“But I’m starting to realize something.”

“What?” Marcos asked.

Adrián shrugged.

“I’m not sure I actually know what it means.”

The others looked at him.

Matías spoke first.

“You mean *flesh*?”

“Yes.”

Adrián nodded.

“We keep saying Corinth was fleshly.”

“And Galatia.”

“And possibly Ephesus.”

“And Laodicea.”

He paused.

“But what exactly are we saying?”

Marcos leaned back.

“That’s a fair question.”

Matías answered quickly.

“It’s sin.”

Adrián looked at him.

“Obvious sin?”

“Yes.”

“Immorality.”

“Drunkenness.”

“Those kinds of things.”

Adrián nodded slowly.

“That would explain Corinth.”

“Yes,” Matías said.

“But not the others.”

Marcos spoke.

“Galatia wasn’t immoral.”

“No,” Matías admitted.

“They were serious about obedience.”

Elías added quietly,

“Very serious.”

Adrián rubbed his chin.

“And Ephesus was doctrinally careful.”

“Yes.”

“And Laodicea was confident and successful.”

The table grew quiet again.

Finally Marcos said what all of them were thinking.

“So carnality must mean something more than obvious sin.”

Matías frowned slightly.

“What else could it mean?”

Elías spoke slowly.

“The word Paul uses in 1 Corinthians is interesting.”

Marcos looked up.

“Which word?”

“*Sarkikos*.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“Well sir...greek then huh. Here we go.”

Elías continued calmly.

“Yes, it literally means *of the flesh*.”

Matías nodded.

“Honestly, that doesn’t clarify much.”

“No,” Elías admitted.

“But the context might.”

Marcos opened the Bible.

“Let’s look at it.”

He turned to 1 Corinthians 3.

Adrián read aloud of his new NIV Bible.

“Brothers and sisters, I could not address you as people who live by the Spirit but as people who are still worldly...”

He paused.

“That’s the passage. Interestingly the NIV translates fleshly as worldly.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

Adrián continued.

“mere infants in Christ.”

Matías frowned.

“They were immature.”

“Yes.”

Adrián read further.

“For since there is jealousy and quarreling among you, are you not worldly?”

He stopped.

“That seems straightforward.”

Marcos nodded.

“Jealousy and strife.”

“That’s the evidence.”

Matías leaned forward.

“So worldly means sinful behavior.”

“Possibly,” Marcos said.

“But the passage doesn’t stop there.”

Adrián looked down again and continued reading.

“For when one says, “I follow Paul,” and another,
“I follow Apollos” ...”

He paused.

“...are you not mere human beings?”

The table was quiet.

Matías spoke slowly.

“That sounds like pride.”

“Yes.”

“Division.”

“Yes.”

Adrián leaned back.

“So worldliness or the flesh shows up as jealousy...”

“...strife...”

“...division.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

But Elías was still looking at the passage.

“There’s something else here.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

Elías pointed to the text.

“They were still called *brothers*.”

Matías nodded.

“Yes.”

“And Paul still called them *infants in Christ*.”

Marcos leaned forward.

“So they were believers.”

“Yes.”

“But still fleshly.”

Adrián thought about that.

“That’s uncomfortable.”

“Why?” Matías asked.

“Because we tend to separate those two things.”

“What do you mean?”

“We assume flesh equals unbeliever.”

Elías shook his head slightly.

“Paul didn’t say that.”

Matías looked thoughtful.

“So believers can live according to the flesh.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

Adrián tapped the table lightly.

“Okay.”

“So flesh is more than just immoral behavior.”

“Yes.”

“And it’s possible even in a church full of believers.”

“Yes.”

“But that still leaves the question.”

“Question? What question?” Matías asked.

Adrián looked around the table.

“What exactly is the flesh?”

No one answered immediately.

Because each of them realized something.

They had used the word many times.

But none of them had ever stopped to carefully define it from Scripture.

Marcos finally spoke.

“If we’re going to continue this investigation...”

He looked at the others.

“...we probably need to answer that question.”

Elías nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

Matías folded his arms.

“So where do we start?”

Marcos answered simply.

“With the passages.”

Adrián smiled.

“That sounds like a long evening.”

Marcos nodded.

“It might be.”

Adrián leaned back.

“Well...”

He looked at the Bible again.

“...I guess we finally have our real question.”

The others looked at him.

Adrián said it plainly.

“If carnality can look like Corinth...”

“...or Galatia...”

“...or Ephesus...”

“...or Laodicea...”

He paused.

“...then what exactly does the Bible mean when it says *flesh*?”

And with that question, the investigation finally turned where it should have started all along.

To the Scriptures themselves.

Chapter 17

Four Definitions

The question lingered longer than anyone expected.

What exactly is the flesh?

They had used the word easily.

Almost casually.

But once they tried to define it, the room became quieter.

Finally Adrián broke the silence.

“Well,” he said, “someone has to go first.”

Matías nodded, pointing at Adrian.

“You started the question.”

“Which means I should start the trouble?”

Marcos smiled faintly.

“That seems fair.”

Adrián shrugged.

“Alright then.”

He leaned forward.

“To me it seems pretty simple.”

The others waited.

“The flesh is when people live according to their sinful desires.”

Matías nodded immediately.

“That makes sense.”

Adrián continued.

“You see it clearly in Corinth.”

“Pride.”

“Jealousy.”

“Immorality.”

“People doing whatever they feel is right.”

He shrugged again.

“That’s the flesh.”

Matías nodded.

“Yes.”

“That fits.”

But Elías didn’t look fully convinced.

Adrián noticed.

“What’s wrong?”

Elías spoke carefully.

“That definition works for Corinth. I can agree with that.”

“Ok, but I sense your hesitation...”

“But it doesn’t explain Galatia.”

Adrián tilted his head.

“How not?”

“They weren’t chasing sinful desires.”

“They were trying to obey God.”

Adrián thought about that.

“Fair point.”

Matías leaned forward slightly.

“That’s exactly why I see it differently.”

The others looked at him.

Matías opened his worn KJV Bible he carried with him and turned a few pages carefully.

“Scripture does warn us about this.”

He cleared his throat and read slowly, in the familiar language he had learned years ago.

“Wherefore come out from among them, and be ye separate, saith the Lord, and touch not the unclean thing; and I will receive you.”

Matías closed the Bible gently.

“That’s not management of the flesh,” he said. “That’s separation.”

Adrián tilted his head slightly.

“But separation from what?”

Matías answered without hesitation.

“From the things that lead us into the flesh.”

Elías watched him quietly.

“And who decides what those things are?”

For a moment Matías did not answer.

Adrián smiled.

“Here we go.”

Matías spoke slowly.

“I think the flesh is when people stop taking holiness seriously.”

Adrián raised an eyebrow.

“Well sir. You need to explain that.”

“When discipline disappears.”

“When people stop guarding their lives.”

“When they assume grace will cover everything.”

Marcos looked thoughtful.

“So for you the flesh is lack of discipline.”

“Of course, don’t you?”

Matías nodded firmly.

“Exactly.”

Adrián laughed softly.

“That sounds like half the churches I’ve ever visited.”

Matías didn’t laugh.

“Holiness matters.”

“No one disagrees with that,” Elías said.

Matías continued.

“When people begin relaxing their standards...”

“...the flesh takes over.”

Adrián leaned back.

“So the cure is stronger discipline?”

Matías shrugged.

“Obviously. You can’t expect to have Christ-like character without spiritual discipline.”

Marcos looked toward Elías.

“You haven’t said anything yet.”

Elías spoke quietly.

“My understanding is slightly different.”

Adrián smiled.

“Well sir, I’m shocked.”

Elías ignored the comment.

“To me the flesh shows up when truth is compromised.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“That’s interesting.”

Elías continued.

“False ideas about God.”

“Careless teaching.”

“Doctrinal confusion.”

Adrián chuckled.

“That sounds exactly like you.”

Elías didn’t deny it.

“When truth becomes unclear...”

“...people begin drifting.”

Marcos asked,

“So the flesh, in your view, is doctrinal error?”

“In many cases, ultimately, yes.”

Adrián rubbed his chin.

“That explains why you were so interested in Ephesus.”

“Yes.”

“They defended truth.”

“But Christ still corrected them,” Marcos said quietly.

Elías nodded slowly.

“Yes, that’s why it’s interesting to me.”

The table grew quiet again.

Three definitions.

Sinful behavior.

Lack of discipline.

Doctrinal compromise.

Adrián finally looked at Marcos.

“You’ve been suspiciously quiet.”

Marcos smiled faintly.

“That’s because I’m not sure any of those explanations fully work.”

Matías frowned.

“What do you mean?”

Marcos leaned forward slightly.

“All three definitions describe real problems.”

“Yes.”

“But none of them explains every church we looked at.”

Adrián nodded.

“That’s true.”

Marcos continued.

“Corinth fits Adrián’s definition.”

“Yes.”

“Galatia fits Matías’ concern.”

“Yes.”

“And Ephesus relates to Elías’ warning.”

“Yes.”

“But Laodicea...”

He paused.

“...doesn’t fit neatly into any of them.”

Matías thought about that.

“They weren’t immoral.”

“No.”

“They weren’t careless.”

“No.”

“They weren’t doctrinally chaotic.”

“No.”

Adrián looked puzzled.

“So what was their problem?”

Marcos answered slowly.

“That’s exactly the question.”

Elías leaned forward slightly.

“So how would you define the flesh?”

Marcos hesitated.

“I’m not ready to define it yet.”

Adrián laughed.

“Well sir. That’s convenient.”

Marcos smiled.

“I’m serious.”

“Why.”

“Because the passages we’ve read seem to point to something deeper.”

Matías crossed his arms.

“Deeper how.”

Marcos spoke carefully.

“In every case...”

“...the people involved believed they were doing the right thing.”

The table went quiet.

Adrián thought about it.

“Corinth thought they were spiritually gifted.”

“Yes.”

“Galatia thought they were protecting holiness.”

“Yes.”

“Ephesus thought they were defending truth.”

“Yes.”

“And Laodicea thought they were successful.”

“Yes.”

Marcos nodded slowly.

“And yet Christ corrected all of them.”

Elías looked thoughtful.

“So you think the flesh might be something more subtle.”

“I’m not certain, but something we haven’t considered yet.”

“Something that can hide even inside sincere efforts to serve God.”

The words settled heavily on the table.

Matías finally spoke.

“That’s a troubling thought.”

Adrián nodded.

“Yes it is.”

Marcos leaned back slightly.

“I think we need to look at more passages.”

Marcos nodded.

“Which ones?”

Elías answered quietly.

“Romans.”

“Galatians.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“Well then.”

He tapped the Bible lightly.

“Looks like this investigation is just getting started.”

Chapter 18

The Passage They Couldn't Ignore



The next evening they met again.

Same place.

Same table.

Adrián was already there.

Of course.

He was leaning over the counter talking with the girl behind the register as if they had known each other for years.

Matías walked in first.

He nodded toward the counter.

“Already making friends?”

Adrián grinned.

“Someone has to keep this place alive.”

Matías sat down quietly.

A moment later Elías arrived, carrying a Bible that already looked heavily marked.

Marcos came in last.

Adrián finally left the counter and joined them.

“Well,” he said.

“Did anyone do their homework?”

Marcos smiled.

“You make it sound like a school assignment.”

“It feels like one,” Adrián replied.

“Can i get your orders? I’m inviting tonight”.

They all answered in a single voice, “the usual”.

A couple of minutes later her returned with 4 mugs of coffee.

“That was fast”

“Let’s get started” Adrian urged.

Elías then opened his Bible immediately.

“I think we should start with Galatians.”

Matías looked up.

“Why Galatians?”

Elías answered simply.

“Because Paul says something there that I find impossible to ignore.”

Adrián leaned forward.

“Well sir. Now you have my attention.”

Elías turned a few pages and began reading.

“You foolish Galatians, who has bewitched you?”

Adrián raised an eyebrow.

“That’s not a gentle opening.”

“No,” Marcos said.

“It isn’t. That’s harsh for someone is who trying hard to be obe-

dient.”

Elías continued.

“Before whose eyes Jesus Christ was publicly portrayed as crucified.”

Matías nodded.

“They had heard the gospel clearly.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

Then he read the next line.

“This is the only thing I want to find out from you...”

Adrián smiled slightly.

“That sounds like a very direct question.”

“Yes.”

Elías read it slowly.

“Did you receive the Spirit by the works of the Law, or by hearing with faith?”

The table was quiet.

Matías answered first.

“By faith.”

“Of course.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“But listen to what Paul says next.”

He read again.

“Are you so foolish?”

Adrián laughed softly.

“Paul is not being subtle.”

Elías continued.

“Having begun by the Spirit...”

He paused.

“...are you now being perfected by the flesh?”

The sentence hung in the air.

No one spoke.

Matías finally said what everyone was thinking.

“Ok. I’m not going to lie...that’s strange.”

Marcos frowned.

“How so?”

Matías gestured toward the text.

“They began correctly.”

“Yes.”

“By the Spirit.”

“Yes.”

“But Paul says they were now trying to continue...”

He tapped the verse lightly.

“...by the flesh.”

Adrian leaned forward.

“That sounds like effort.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

Religious effort.

The table grew quiet again.

Adrián spoke slowly.

“So let me understand this.”

“Galatia wasn’t immoral.”

“No,” Marcos said.

“They were trying to obey God.”

“Yes.”

“They were serious about holiness.”

“Yes.”

Adrián looked back at the verse.

“And Paul still calls that flesh.”

No one answered. The coffee lingered in the air.

Because the implication was becoming obvious.

Matías spoke quietly.

“That’s difficult to accept.”

“Why,” Adrián asked.

Matías hesitated.

“Because effort is how we usually fight sin.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“But according to Paul...”

He pointed to the passage.

“...that effort itself can be the flesh.”

Elías spoke carefully.

“Paul isn’t attacking obedience.”

“No.”

“He’s confronting the source of it.”

Adrián frowned slightly.

“What do you mean?”

Elías answered slowly.

“They began by depending on the Spirit.”

“Yes.”

“But now they were depending on themselves.”

The words settled heavily over the table.

Matías leaned back.

“That’s unsettling.”

“Why,” Marcos asked.

“Because it means the flesh can appear...”

He searched for the right words.

“...very spiritual.”

Adrián laughed quietly.

“That might explain Galatia.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“But it might explain something else too.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

Marcos looked around the table.

“It might explain Ephesus.”

Elías looked down at the passage again.

“And possibly Laodicea.”

Adrián leaned back slowly.

“So the flesh isn’t just sinful behavior.”

“No.”

“And it isn’t simply lack of discipline.”

“No.”

“And it isn’t only doctrinal confusion.”

“No.”

Matías spoke quietly.

“It might actually be something far more common.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

Matías answered carefully.

“Trying to live the Christian life by our own strength.”

No one spoke.

Because every one of them knew that described something painfully familiar.

Adrián finally said what none of them were ready to say out loud.

“If that’s true...”

He looked at the others.

“...then carnality might be much closer to us than we think.”

The table fell silent again.

Because the investigation had just crossed a line.

They were no longer studying distant churches.

They were beginning to study themselves.

Chapter 19

The Passage That Made Them Uncomfortable



The table stayed quiet longer than usual.

No one rushed to speak.

Galatians had already unsettled them.

Adrián finally broke the silence.

“Well sir.”

He leaned back slightly.

“That was... slightly...unpleasant.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“Indeed.”

Adrián looked at him.

“You don’t like the idea that effort can be flesh.”

Matías didn’t answer immediately.

“No,” he said finally.

“I don’t.”

Marcos looked down at his Bible.

“There’s another passage.”

Adrián sighed.

“That doesn’t sound encouraging.”

Marcos smiled faintly.

“It probably won’t be.”

Elías leaned forward.

“Where?”

“Romans.”

Adrián laughed softly.

“That’s never a light conversation.”

Marcos turned to the passage.

“Romans chapter eight.”

Matías nodded.

“That’s a beautiful chapter.”

“Yes, but look what it says here...”

Marcos read quietly.

“For those who are according to the flesh set their
minds on the things of the flesh...”

He paused.

“...but those who are according to the Spirit, the
things of the Spirit.”

Adrián rubbed his chin.

“That sounds like two directions.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“Two completely different orientations.”

Matías nodded.

“Flesh versus Spirit.”

Marcos continued reading.

“For the mind set on the flesh is death...”

Adrián frowned.

“That escalated quickly.”

Marcos finished the sentence.

“...but the mind set on the Spirit is life and peace.”

The table was quiet again.

Elías spoke carefully.

“That doesn’t sound like a small difference.”

“No,” Marcos said.

“It sounds absolute.”

Matías leaned forward slightly.

“Read the next verse.”

Marcos did.

“Because the mind set on the flesh is hostile toward
God...”

Adrián raised an eyebrow.

“Hostile?”

“Yes.”

Marcos continued.

“...for it does not subject itself to the law of God, for it is not even able to do so.”

Adrián looked puzzled.

“Wait.”

“That doesn’t sound right.”

Matías looked at him.

“What do you mean?”

Adrián gestured toward the text.

“That sounds like rebellion.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“But Galatia wasn’t rebelling.”

“They were trying to obey.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“That’s true.”

Adrián leaned forward.

“So how can Paul call something hostile to God...”

He tapped the page.

“...when the people involved were trying to do the right thing?”

No one answered immediately.

Because that question was the heart of the problem.

Adrián sat back.

“That’s disturbing.”

“Why?” Marcos asked.

Adrián shrugged.

“Because most christian effort is aimed at pleasing God.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“But Paul says something important.”

“What,” Matías asked.

“That effort, if it comes from the flesh...”

He pointed to the verse.

“...cannot please Him.”

The table went quiet again.

Matías finally spoke.

“So now we have two statements.”

Adrián nodded.

“From Galatians.”

“Yes.”

“And from Romans.”

Matías repeated them slowly.

“Beginning by the Spirit...”

“...but trying to continue by the flesh.”

“And...”

He looked down at the page.

“...those who are in the flesh cannot please God.”

Adrián leaned back.

“That creates a serious problem.”

“Problem, why?” Elías asked.

Adrián looked around the table.

“If the flesh cannot please God...”

He paused.

“...then religious effort alone doesn’t solve carnality.”

Matías looked down at his hands.

“I’ll be honest, that’s real difficult to accept.”

Marcos spoke quietly.

“But now I see, it explains something.”

“What?” Adrián asked.

“Why churches can appear very serious...”

“...very disciplined...”

“...very correct...”

“...and still remain carnal.”

The words hung in the air.

Elías finally spoke.

“So the real question becomes...”

He looked at the others.

“...what exactly produces the Christian life?”

Adrián nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

“Because if it isn’t human effort...”

“...then something else must be happening.”

Matías looked back at the passage.

“The only other one mentioned is the Spirit.”

“Yes,” Marcos said quietly.

“The Spirit.”

Adrián exhaled slowly.

“Well sir.”

He looked around the table.

“I think this investigation just became a lot more personal.”

No one disagreed.

Because every one of them had just realized something unsettling.

They had spent years trying to fight the flesh.

But they had never seriously considered the possibility that the struggle itself...

might sometimes be coming from the flesh.

Matías looked up immediately.

“Wait.”

The others turned toward him.

“What do you mean *sometimes*?”

Adrián shrugged slightly.

“Well... you know.”

“Sometimes we try too hard.”

Matías shook his head.

“No.”

“That’s not what Paul said.”

The table went quiet again.

Elías looked down at the passage.

“He’s right.”

Adrián frowned.

“What do you mean?”

Elías tapped the verse gently.

“Paul didn’t say the flesh sometimes fails to please God.”

He read the line again slowly.

“Those who are in the flesh cannot please God.”

Adrián leaned forward again.

“So?”

“So the problem isn’t that the flesh fails occasionally.”

Elías looked up.

“The problem is that the flesh cannot produce the Christian life at all.”

The words hung in the air.

Marcos spoke quietly.

“That would mean something important.”

“What?” Adrián asked.

“It would mean that trying harder...”

He paused.

“...doesn’t actually solve carnality.”

Matías finished the thought.

“It might actually be part of it.”

No one spoke for a moment.

Because that possibility was far more unsettling than anything they had discussed so far.

Adrián finally said what everyone was thinking.

“Well...”

He leaned back slowly.

“That changes the whole investigation.”

Chapter 20

The List They Didn't Expect



The next evening the table filled quickly.

When Adrián arrived, the other three were already at the table.

He came straight to the table.

That alone was unusual.

Matías noticed it immediately.

“You look serious.”

Adrián shrugged.

“Don’t get used to it.”

Elías opened his Bible before anyone else spoke.

“I kept thinking about Galatians.”

Marcos nodded.

“That makes sense.”

“If Paul confronted the Galatians for trying to continue by the flesh...”

He turned a few pages.

“...then we should probably read the passage where he actually describes it.”

Adrián leaned forward.

“You mean the famous one.”

“Yes.”

Matías nodded.

“The works of the flesh.”

Elías read slowly.

“Now the deeds of the flesh are evident...”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“Well that should simplify things.”

Elías continued.

“Immorality, impurity, sensuality...”

Adrián nodded.

“Corinth.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“That part fits easily.”

Elías kept reading.

“Idolatry, sorcery...”

Matías shrugged.

“That’s less common in church.”

Adrián smiled.

“Hopefully.”

But Elías didn’t stop.

He read the next words carefully.

“Enmity...”

He paused.

Then continued.

“Strife...”

The table went quiet.

Elías read again.

“Jealousy...”

Adrián slowly leaned back.

Elías continued.

“Outbursts of anger...”

Matías looked thoughtful now.

Then Elías read the next line.

“Disputes...”

And the next.

“Dissensions...”

And finally.

“Factions.”

No one spoke.

Because every one of them had heard those words before.

Just not in this list.

Adrián was the first to say it out loud.

“That sounds like Corinth.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

Jealousy.

Strife.

Factions.

Matías spoke slowly.

“That’s exactly what Paul confronted there.”

Elías looked down at the page again.

“But notice something.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

“These are not immoral behaviors.”

Adrián frowned.

“What do you mean?”

“They are relational.”

The table sat quietly.

Marcos spoke.

“Conflicts.”

“Divisions.”

“Group loyalties.”

Adrián nodded slowly.

“That’s exactly what Corinth had.”

“Yes.”

Matías leaned forward.

“And what Galatia was heading toward.”

“Yes.”

Elías turned the page slightly.

“Paul actually lists the same pattern elsewhere.”

“Where,” Adrián asked.

Elías answered.

“First Corinthians.”

Matías nodded.

“Jealousy and strife.”

“Yes.”

Adrián rubbed his chin.

“So the works of the flesh are not just immoral sins.”

“No,” Marcos said.

“They include the kinds of conflicts churches constantly struggle with.”

The words sat heavily on the table.

Adrián spoke slowly.

“That changes how I think about carnality.”

Matías nodded.

“Yes me too.”

“I think most people assume carnality means scandal.”

“But Paul seems more concerned about division.”

Marcos leaned forward slightly.

“So the flesh shows itself not only in obvious sin...”

“...but in the way people relate to one another.”

Adrián nodded slowly.

“That explains a lot.”

“What do you mean,” Matías asked.

“Church arguments.”

“Leadership conflicts.”

“Groups forming around personalities.”

He smiled faintly.

“Sound familiar?”

Marcos nodded.

“Very.”

Elías looked thoughtful.

“That might explain why Paul was so direct with Corinth.”

Adrián leaned back.

“Because they were calling something spiritual...”

He gestured slightly.

“...that Paul was calling flesh.”

Matías spoke quietly.

“I’m not going to lie. That’s uncomfortable.”

“Why,” Adrián asked.

Matías answered carefully.

“Because most churches treat those kinds of conflicts as normal.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“They manage them.”

Adrián laughed softly.

“Church politics.”

“Kind of.”

Elías closed the Bible slowly.

“But Paul didn’t treat them as normal.”

“What did he call them?” Adrián asked.

Elías answered plainly.

“Works of the flesh.”

The table went quiet again.

Because something had now become painfully clear.

Carnality was not merely about scandal.

It was about something much closer to home.

Jealousy.

Strife.

Factions.

The very things churches often learn to tolerate.

Adrián finally spoke.

“So let me ask something.”

The others looked at him.

“If Paul already diagnosed the works of the flesh...”

He paused.

“...then why do churches spend so much time trying to manage them instead of confronting them?”

No one answered.

Because that question was about to open an entirely new part of the journey towards arriving at solving the carnal church.

Chapter 21

Carnality Management



The question stayed on the table longer than any of them expected.

Why do churches spend so much time trying to manage the works of the flesh instead of confronting them?

No one answered right away.

Adrián was the first to speak.

“Maybe because they don’t know what else to do.”

Marcos nodded slowly.

“That’s probably true.”

Matías leaned back.

“Or maybe because they’re trying to protect the church.”

Elías looked at him.

“Protect it from what?”

“Chaos.”

“Division.”

“People doing whatever they want.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“That sounds noble.”

“It is noble,” Matías said.

“At least the concern is.”

No one argued with that.

Marcos finally spoke.

“But that still doesn’t answer the question.”

“What question?” Adrián asked.

“Why churches seem so prepared to live with carnality.”

That sat there.

Adrián rubbed his chin.

“You mean like... expecting it?”

“Yes.”

“Planning around it.”

“Building systems for it.”

The table was quiet again.

Then Matías said something very familiar.

“Well, all churches have leaders that are a little legalistic.”

No one said anything for a moment.

Adrián looked at him.

“That’s exactly the kind of sentence people say.”

Matías frowned.

“What.”

“As if that explains everything.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“As if a little flesh is just part of the furniture.”

Elías spoke quietly.

“Maybe that’s exactly the problem.”

They all looked at him.

“What do you mean,” Adrián asked.

Elías folded his hands.

“Maybe we’ve accepted carnality as normal.”

Adrián laughed softly.

“Well sir. That’s honest.”

“Is it false?” Elías asked.

No one answered immediately.

Because they had all heard the language.

We need to stay united.

Don’t cause waves.

That brother means well.

Yes, he’s stubborn, but he loves God.

He’s a little harsh, but he’s serious about holiness.

They sat with it.

Marcos broke the silence.

“I’ve heard people say things like that my whole life.”

“What things?” Adrián asked.

“That a little pressure is good for people.”

“That they need conviction.”

“That if you preach too much grace people will take advantage.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“That’s a genuine concern.”

Adrián looked at him.

“Is it?”

“Yes.”

“Why wouldn’t it be?”

Adrián leaned forward.

“Because people say that sentence all the time and never explain what they mean.”

Matías frowned.

“What sentence.”

Adrián answered immediately.

‘I believe in grace, but I’d never teach it because people would take advantage.’

The words landed hard because all four of them had heard them.

Marcos spoke quietly.

“Yes.”

“And usually right after that comes another one.”

“What.”

‘Where do you draw the line?’

Adrián laughed once.

“There it is.”

Matías didn’t laugh.

“That’s not an unreasonable question.”

“No,” Elías said.

“But it tells you something.”

“What.”

“That the whole way of thinking is still built around control.”

The table went quiet.

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“Managing outcomes.”

“Managing behavior.”

“Managing people.”

Adrián leaned back.

“So instead of dealing with the flesh...”

He paused.

“...we build rails.”

Matías spoke slowly.

“Rails matter.”

“Yes,” Adrián said.

“But rails aren’t life.”

That one sat there.

Elías finally spoke.

“Maybe that’s why so many churches feel heavy.”

No one answered.

Because they all knew what he meant.

Churches where people measured everything.

How often you showed up. How much you gave. How con-

sistent your devotions were. Whether your children behaved properly. Whether your language sounded spiritual enough. Whether your questions were safe enough to ask.

Marcos spoke next.

“And if someone starts pushing on the system...”

He paused.

“...the phrases come out.”

Adrián nodded.

“Yes.”

He started counting them off lightly on his fingers.

“Don’t be rebellious.” “You’re dividing the church.”

“We need to stay united.” “Just leave it alone.” “They’re our brothers.” “Stop causing waves.”

Matías looked down at the table.

“That does happen.”

“Commonly,” Elías said.

“And the language sounds spiritual.”

Marcos nodded.

“But often it just means...”

He finished the thought plainly.

“Don’t disturb the arrangement.”

No one smiled.

Because that felt too close.

Adrián broke the silence again.

“You know another one?”

“What,” Marcos asked.

“That’s hyper-grace.”

He said it with just enough irony to make the others recognize it immediately.

Matías exhaled through his nose.

“Yes.”

“That one too.”

Adrián leaned forward.

“No definition.”

“No explanation.”

“Just a label.”

Elías added quietly,

“The same with antinomianism.” He said with air quotes.

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“People use the word like a hammer.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“And if you ask what they mean...”

He lifted both hands slightly.

“Nothing. Just like so many other theological buzz words in the past that only serve to divide over definitions. ”

Matías finally spoke.

“Not always nothing.”

The others looked at him.

He continued carefully.

“Sometimes they mean...”

He paused.

“They’re afraid people will stop taking obedience seriously.”

Elías nodded.

“That fear is real.”

“Yes.”

“But fear can still organize a church around the wrong thing.”

The words sat heavily over the table.

Marcos spoke next.

“Maybe that’s what carnality management really is.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

Marcos answered slowly.

“It’s when the church stops expecting real freedom...”

...and starts trying to keep the flesh under control.

No one interrupted him.

He continued.

“Not cured.”

“Not confronted at the root.”

“Just managed.”

Adrián rubbed his forehead.

“Well sir. That explains a lot!”

“What?” Matías asked.

“Why so many churches can function for years with the same tensions.”

“The same factions.”

“The same pressure.”

“The same fear.”

He looked around the table.

“They’re not solving the problem.”

“They’re learning to live with it.”

“Instead of being, they’re just playing church.” Adrian chimed.

Elías spoke quietly.

“And sometimes even to protect carnality.”

The others looked at him.

Elías continued.

“If a system is built around controlling carnality...”

He paused.

“...then that system actually depends on carnality continuing.”

No one spoke.

Because the thought was too sharp to move past quickly.

Marcos finally said it out loud.

“So if people were actually free...”

He leaned forward slightly.

“...what would happen to half the systems we’ve built?”

Adrián laughed once, but there was no humor in it.

“Well sir, they’d collapse!”

Matías stared at the table.

“That’s hard to hear. That sound like you’re taking sin lightly.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“But it’s true, I fear we have built programs and systems to manage carnality in church.”

Adrián spoke more quietly now.

“Maybe that’s why so many churches don’t know what to do with grace.”

No one answered.

He kept going.

“Grace sounds too dangerous.”

“Too free.”

“Too open.”

“So people say things like...”

He looked around the table and repeated the line almost wearily.

“Grace is nice, but you can’t be without the law.”

Matías closed his eyes for a moment.

He had heard that sentence too many times.

Marcos spoke carefully.

“And then another system gets built.”

“What kind of system,” Adrián asked.

“One that can survive as long as people keep failing.”

The café noise continued around them.

A cup dropped near the counter.

Someone laughed.

The ordinary world kept moving.

But at the table by the window, something had become painfully clear.

Carnality management was not merely a mistake.

It was a way of arranging church life so that the flesh remained predictable, controllable, and useful.

Adrián finally said what all of them were thinking.

“So let me ask the obvious question.”

The others looked at him.

“If managing carnality doesn’t solve it...”

He paused.

“...what does?”

No one answered. Blank looks. Marcos sipped on his coffee.

Not because the question was unclear.

But because all four of them knew they had just reached the edge of something much bigger than church strategy.

And whatever the answer was...

it would have to go deeper than rules, pressure, labels, or control.

It would have to deal with the flesh itself.

Chapter 22

When Carnality Tries to Cure Carnality



No one spoke for a while.

The question was still sitting there.

If managing carnality doesn't solve it... what does?

Adrián finally broke the silence.

"Well," he said slowly, "churches do try to deal with it."

Matías nodded.

"Yes."

“They discipline people.”

“They correct people.”

“They tighten standards.”

Marcos leaned back slightly.

“That’s true.”

Adrián shrugged.

“That seems reasonable.”

“Does it?” Elías asked.

Adrián looked at him.

“What do you mean?”

Elías spoke carefully.

“Sometimes it seems to help.”

“But sometimes it makes things worse.”

Matías frowned slightly.

“How.”

“Think about it.”

“When someone falls into sin...”

“Yes,” Matías said.

“The church reacts.”

“They bring correction.”

“They apply discipline.”

“That’s biblical,” Matías added.

“Yes,” Elías said.

“No one is arguing with that.”

Marcos spoke next.

“But what happens if the discipline itself comes from the flesh?”

No one answered immediately.

Adrián leaned forward.

“What would that even look like?”

Marcos answered slowly.

“Anger.”

“Pride.”

“Humiliation.”

“Power.”

The table grew quiet.

Matías spoke softly.

“I’ve seen that.”

Adrián nodded.

“So have I and it’s just plain wrong.”

Elías added,

“And when discipline comes from the flesh...”

He paused.

“...what does it produce?”

Marcos answered.

“More flesh.”

No one smiled.

Because they had all seen it.

A person falls.

Leaders react strongly.

People take sides.

Some defend the leaders.

Others defend the person.

Soon the church is full of tension.

And the original problem multiplies.

Adrián spoke quietly.

“I’ve watched entire churches split over situations like that.”

Matías nodded.

“Yes.”

“Instead of restoration...”

“...you get factions.”

Marcos spoke again.

“That’s exactly what Paul listed in Galatians.”

Strife.

Dissensions.

Factions.

Adrián leaned back.

“So carnality reacting to carnality...”

“...creates more carnality.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

Matías thought about it.

“That explains something.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

“Why I’ve seen so many church disciplines end badly.”

Marcos nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

“Because the goal quietly shifts.”

“What goal?” Adrián asked.

“Protecting the system.”

Adrián rubbed his chin.

“That’s uncomfortable.”

Elías added quietly,

“And protecting leaders.”

No one argued.

Matías spoke carefully.

“I’ve heard people say things like...”

He hesitated slightly.

Then finished the thought.

“We need to protect the testimony of the church.”

Adrián nodded.

“Yes.”

“That phrase shows up quickly.”

Marcos added another one.

“We can’t let this spread.”

Elías said another.

“If we don’t deal with this firmly the people will find out.”

Matías nodded.

“And sometimes that concern is real.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“But if the response comes from fear...”

“...or anger...”

“...or pride...”

He paused.

“...then the cure becomes part of the disease.”

The table went quiet again.

Adrián finally said it plainly.

“So carnality cannot cure carnality.”

“No, that’s why Paul called on those who were spiritual to act...”

Elías said.

Brethren, even if a man is caught in any trespass,
you who are spiritual, restore such a one in a spirit
of gentleness...

“Carnality only multiplies it.” Adrian added.

Matías spoke slowly.

“That would explain something else.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

“Why so many churches become harder over time.”

“Harder how?”

“More rules.”

“More caution.”

“More pressure.”

Adrián nodded.

“Yes.”

“They start building systems to keep people in line.”

Marcos smiled faintly.

“And eventually those systems become the identity of the church.”

Elías added quietly,

“And questioning them becomes dangerous.”

Adrián laughed softly.

“Yes.”

He raised a finger slightly.

“Don’t be rebellious.”

The others recognized the line immediately.

Matías added another.

“You’re dividing the church.”

Marcos added another.

“Stop causing waves.”

Elías finished the pattern.

“You need to submit to the leaders”

They sat with that for a moment.

Adrián finally spoke again.

“You know what’s strange?”

“What,” Matías asked.

“All of those sentences sound spiritual.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“But they’re often protecting something very fragile.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

Marcos answered plainly.

“A system that only works if people remain controlled.”

Matías looked down at the table again.

“That’s difficult to hear.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“But if Paul is right...”

He looked back toward the open Bible.

“...then the flesh cannot produce the Christian life.”

Adrián nodded slowly.

“So trying harder doesn’t solve it.”

“No.”

“More rules don’t solve it.”

“No.”

“More pressure doesn’t solve it.”

“No.”

Elias remembered a passage,

why, as if you were living in the world, do you submit yourself to decrees, such as, “Do not handle, do not taste, do not touch!” —in accordance with the commandments and teachings of men? These are matters which have, to be sure, the appearance of wisdom but are of no value against fleshly indul-

gence.

The table sat in silence again.

Finally Adrián said what everyone was starting to feel.

“So if the flesh can’t fix the flesh...”

He looked around the table.

“...then what can?”

No one answered.

But this time the silence felt different.

Because the investigation had now closed every door they usually trusted.

Effort.

Discipline.

Control.

Management.

None of them had solved the problem.

And that meant something else had to exist.

Something deeper.

Something powerful enough to deal with the flesh itself.

Marcos looked down at the Bible again.

Then he said quietly,

“There is one thing Paul keeps returning to.”

The others looked at him.

“What,” Adrián asked.

Marcos answered simply.

“The cross.”

Chapter 23

The Cross Paul Would Not Leave



For several moments no one spoke.

The word had been said almost quietly.

The cross.

Not loudly.

Not as a conclusion.

Just as an observation.

Marcos had not moved.

His hand still rested on the open Bible.

Adrián looked at him.

“You said Paul keeps returning to it.”

“Yes.”

“What do you mean?”

Marcos turned the Bible slightly so the others could see the page.

“Corinth.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“That church again.”

“Yes.”

Marcos nodded.

“That church again.”

He pointed to the opening of the letter.

“When Paul began writing to them...”

He paused.

“...he did something interesting.”

Matías leaned forward slightly.

“What.”

“He didn’t begin by listing their problems.”

Elías nodded.

“That’s true.”

Marcos continued.

“He didn’t start with their divisions.”

“Or their pride.”

“Or their immorality.”

Adrián looked at the text.

“So where did he start?”

Marcos answered quietly.

“With the cross.”

The table sat quietly again.

Adrián spoke first.

“That seems obvious.”

“Does it?” Marcos asked.

Adrián shrugged.

“Well... that’s the gospel. But then he must teach what we must do to deal with the flesh.”

“Yes, the cross is the gospel.”

“But listen to how Paul says it.”

Marcos began reading slowly.

“For the word of the cross is foolishness to those who are perishing...”

He paused.

“...but to us who are being saved it is the power of God.”

Matías nodded.

“Yes.”

“I’ve heard that verse many times. That doesn’t answer our questions.”

Marcos looked up.

“I’ve heard it too.”

“But I’m beginning to notice something.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

“Paul doesn’t treat the cross as an introduction.”

The others watched him with curious looks.

“What do you mean?” Elías asked.

Marcos answered carefully.

“He treats it as the center.”

He turned another page.

“And he keeps returning to it.”

Adrián leaned forward again.

“Show us.”

Marcos read again.

“For indeed Jews ask for signs and Greeks search
for wisdom...”

Then he finished the sentence.

“But we preach Christ crucified.”

The words sat there quietly.

Adrián spoke slowly.

“That’s a strange message.”

“Why,” Matías asked.

“Because it doesn’t sound like a strategy.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“It isn’t a strategy.”

Elías spoke quietly.

“It’s a declaration.”

Marcos continued.

“Paul says something else right after that.”

He read again.

“But to those who are called... Christ the power of
God and the wisdom of God.”

Adrián rubbed his chin.

“So the cross isn’t just about forgiveness.”

“No,” Marcos said.

“It’s power.”

Matías looked thoughtful.

“Power for what?”

Marcos didn’t answer immediately.

Instead he turned a few pages.

“Listen to something Paul says later in the same letter.”

He read slowly.

“For I determined to know nothing among you except Jesus Christ, and Him crucified.”

Adrián blinked.

“Nothing?”

“Yes.”

“That sounds extreme.”

Elías nodded.

“It does.”

Adrián looked puzzled.

“Why would Paul say that to a church full of problems?”

Matías answered quietly.

“Good question. I was wondering the same thing.”

The table was silent again.

Marcos spoke slowly.

“We’ve spent the last few days asking how churches deal with carnality.”

Adrián nodded.

“Yes.”

“Rules.”

“Pressure.”

“Management.”

“Systems.”

Marcos gestured toward the open Bible.

“But Paul keeps pointing to something else.”

“The cross.”

Matías leaned forward slightly.

“Are you saying the cross solves carnality?”

Marcos answered carefully.

“I’m saying Paul never leaves it.”

Elías looked down at the passage again.

“That’s true.”

“In every church we’ve discussed...”

He paused.

“...Paul keeps bringing them back to Christ crucified.”

Adrián sat back slowly.

“That’s interesting.”

“What’s interesting?” Matías asked.

“All of our solutions have been about behavior.”

He gestured lightly.

“But Paul keeps pointing to something deeper.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“The source.”

Elías spoke quietly.

“If the flesh cannot please God...”

He looked at the others.

“...then the answer must come from somewhere outside the flesh.”

Matías looked at the page again.

“The cross.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“The cross.”

The café noise continued quietly around them.

Cups moving.

Low conversations.

Ordinary sounds.

But at the small table by the window, something had begun to settle in.

For years they had heard the message of the cross.

They had believed it.

They had preached it.

But mostly as the beginning of the Christian life.

Forgiveness.

Conversion.

Salvation.

And now they were beginning to see something they had overlooked.

Paul did not treat the cross as the beginning only.

He treated it as the center.

The power.

The answer to the very problem they had been trying to solve.

Adrián finally spoke.

“Maybe that’s why we’ve struggled.”

The others looked at him.

“What do you mean?” Matías asked.

Adrián answered slowly.

“Maybe we’ve been trying to solve carnality...”

He paused.

“...without understanding what the cross actually did.”

No one spoke for a moment.

Because that thought was both simple and enormous.

Marcos finally closed the Bible gently.

“If that’s true...”

He looked around the table.

“...then our investigation is about to change direction.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“How.”

Marcos answered calmly.

“We stop asking how to control the flesh.”

“And start asking what the cross actually did to it.”

The table fell quiet again.

Because that question...

was about to open the most important part of the investigation yet.

Chapter 24

The Cross Does Not Bow to Carnality



The next evening they met again.

No one suggested a different topic.

The direction of the conversation had already been decided.

Adrián arrived first as usual.

But he wasn't talking at the counter.

He was sitting at the table, quietly stirring his coffee.

Matías noticed it immediately.

“You look thoughtful.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“That happens occasionally.”

Matías sat down across from him.

“I’ve been thinking about what we said yesterday.”

“The cross?”

“Yes.”

Adrián nodded slowly.

“Me too.”

Elías arrived next, Bible already in hand.

Marcos came in last.

No one wasted time.

Adrián finally spoke.

“So if the cross is the answer...”

He paused.

“...then we need to understand what it actually does.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“Paul seems to connect the cross with something very specific.”

“What,” Matías asked.

“The flesh.”

Elías turned quickly to Galatians again.

“There’s a passage.”

Adrián smiled.

“Well sir. There’s always a passage.”

Elías read slowly.

“But may it never be that I would boast, except in
the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ...”

He paused briefly.

Then finished the sentence.

“...through which the world has been crucified to
me, and I to the world.”

The table was quiet.

Matías spoke first.

“That’s powerful language.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“Crucifixion is not a gentle idea.”

Adrián leaned forward.

“What exactly is Paul saying there?”

Elías answered carefully.

“He’s saying something decisive happened.”

“What kind of thing?”

“A separation.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

“The world no longer governs him.”

Adrián looked thoughtful.

“That’s interesting.”

“What is?” Marcos asked.

“Because crucifixion isn’t negotiation.”

The others looked at him.

Adrián continued.

“It’s final.”

The word sat quietly on the table.

Final.

Elías nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

“And Paul speaks about it as something already accomplished.”

Marcos added,

“The cross did not merely advise the flesh.”

“It ended its authority.”

Matías leaned back slightly.

“That’s very different from how churches often approach carnality.”

Adrián nodded.

“Yes.”

“Most systems try to control it.”

“Balance it.”

“Manage it.”

Marcos spoke quietly.

“But the cross does something else.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

“It exposes it.”

The table went quiet again.

Elías turned to another passage.

“Paul says something similar in Romans.”

He read slowly.

“Our old self was crucified with Him...”

Adrián frowned slightly.

“Crucified again.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

Matías spoke carefully.

“That language is absolute.”

“Yes.”

“Crucifixion doesn’t leave room for improvement.”

Marcos nodded.

“It declares an end.”

Adrián leaned back.

“So the cross does not cooperate with the flesh.”

“No.”

“It does not train it.”

“No.”

“It does not refine it.”

“No.”

Elías spoke quietly.

“It condemns it.”

The café noise continued softly around them.

But the table had grown still.

Matías spoke next.

“That explains something.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

“Why the message of the cross always feels offensive.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“Because it does not flatter human effort.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“Well sir, that is profound.”

“Yes, the cross removes it.”

Elías looked down at the passage again.

“That’s exactly why Paul said the word of the cross is foolishness to many.”

“Why?” Matías asked.

“Because people naturally want something else.”

“What.”

Adrián answered.

“Improvement.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“People want the flesh corrected.”

“Strengthened.”

“Disciplined.”

“But the cross does something far more radical.”

The others waited.

Marcos finished the thought quietly.

“It declares the flesh finished.”

No one spoke for a moment.

Because that was not how most of them had thought about it.

Adrián finally said what everyone was realizing.

“So the cross doesn’t bow to carnality.”

“No,” Elías said.

“It stands against it.”

Matías spoke carefully.

“That would explain something else.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

“Why churches sometimes soften the message.”

Marcos nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

“They emphasize effort.”

“Growth.”

“Discipline.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“But not crucifixion.”

“No,” Elías said.

“Because crucifixion removes human pride. It doesn’t leave room for cooperating. The cross is absolute.”

The table grew quiet again.

Adrián finally said it out loud.

“Maybe that’s why Paul refused to leave the cross.”

The others looked at him.

He continued.

“If carnality is the problem...”

He gestured lightly toward the Bible.

“...then the cross is the only message that actually confronts it.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“And that means something important.”

“What,” Matías asked.

“The cross will never adjust itself to fit carnality.”

The words settled heavily over the table.

Adrián looked down at his coffee.

“So if a church builds its life around controlling the flesh...”

He paused.

“...the cross will always disturb that system.”

No one disagreed. But there was a long, sullen silence.

They were just beginning to see something clearly.

The cross does not bow.

It does not soften.

It does not negotiate with the flesh.

It declares its end.

And that is exactly why it is both feared...

and powerful.

Chapter 25

The Cross Is Not Deceived by Carnality



The conversation continued the next evening.

But something had shifted.

Before, the men had been examining churches.

Now they were examining the cross.

Adrián spoke first.

“So yesterday we said something important.”

Matías nodded.

“The cross does not bow to carnality.”

“Yes.”

Adrián stirred his coffee slowly.

“And that explains why it makes people uncomfortable.”

Elías looked up from the Bible.

“Why.”

“Because it removes every human advantage.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“No pride.”

“No accomplishment.”

“No system strong enough to stand beside it.”

Matías leaned forward slightly.

“But there’s another thing we need to consider.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

“How carnality survives.”

The others looked at him.

“What do you mean?” Marcos said.

Matías answered carefully.

“Carnality rarely presents itself honestly.”

The table grew quiet.

Adrián smiled faintly.

“That’s true.”

“No one says...”

He paused,

“I would like to operate in the flesh today.”

The others laughed softly.

Matías continued.

“It usually sounds much better than that.”

Elías nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

“Much better.”

Marcos leaned forward slightly.

“Give an example.”

Matías didn’t hesitate.

“We need to stay united.”

The others recognized the phrase immediately.

Adrián nodded.

“That one shows up quickly.”

Elías added another.

“Don’t cause division.”

Marcos spoke next.

“Stop stirring things up.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“Just leave it alone.”

They sat quietly for a moment.

Matías spoke again.

“None of those sentences sound wrong.”

“No,” Marcos said.

“In fact they sound responsible.”

Adrián nodded.

“Yes.”

“But sometimes they protect the wrong thing.”

Elías spoke quietly.

“What.”

“Systems.”

“Leaders.”

“Traditions.”

The words settled on the table.

Marcos leaned back slightly.

“That’s where the cross becomes uncomfortable.”

“Why?” Adrián asked.

“Because the cross sees through those disguises.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

“The cross is not impressed by spiritual language.”

Adrián smiled.

“Man, that sounds blunt.”

“It is,” Marcos said.

“Paul says something similar in Corinthians.”

He opened the Bible again.

“Listen.”

He read slowly.

“For the word of the cross is foolishness to those

who are perishing...”

He paused.

“...but to us who are being saved it is the power of God.”

Adrián nodded.

“We read that yesterday.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“But Paul keeps going.”

He read again.

“Where is the wise man? Where is the scribe? Where
is the debater of this age?”

The others listened carefully.

Marcos finished the thought.

“Has not God made foolish the wisdom of the world?”

Adrián leaned forward.

“So the cross exposes something.”

“Yes.”

“What.”

“Human wisdom.”

Elías nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

“The ways we justify ourselves.”

Matías spoke quietly.

“And the ways we protect ourselves.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“That explains something else.”

“What,” Marcos asked.

“Why people sometimes resist the message of grace.”

The others looked at him.

Adrián continued.

“They say things like...”

He paused and quoted a phrase they all knew.

“Grace is nice, but you can’t be without the law.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

“I’ve heard that sentence many times.”

Elías added another.

“All you talk about is grace.”

Marcos spoke next.

“People will take advantage.”

Adrián smiled again.

“That one shows up immediately.”

The table sat quietly.

Matías spoke carefully.

“The concern behind those statements is not always wrong.”

“No,” Marcos said.

“But sometimes it hides something else.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

“Fear.”

Elías nodded.

“Yes.”

“Fear of losing control.”

The words were simple.

But they landed heavily.

Adrián leaned back.

“That makes sense.”

“What does?” Matías asked.

“If a church is built around managing carnality...”

He gestured slightly.

“...then grace sounds dangerous.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“Because grace removes the controls.”

Matías spoke quietly.

“And the cross removes the pride.”

Elías added softly.

“And the cross exposes the flesh.”

The table grew quiet again.

Adrián finally said something almost thoughtfully.

“You know what I’m starting to notice?”

“What,” Marcos asked.

“Carnality is clever.”

Matías nodded.

“Yes.”

“It knows how to survive.”

“How?” Marcos asked.

“By sounding spiritual.”

The café noise filled the silence for a moment.

Then Marcos spoke again.

“That’s exactly why Paul refused to move away from the cross.”

The others looked at him.

He continued calmly.

“The cross cuts through every disguise.”

“Pride.”

“Effort.”

“Control.”

“Fear.”

Adrián nodded slowly.

“So the cross is not deceived by carnality.”

“No,” Elías said.

“It sees it clearly.”

Matías leaned forward slightly.

“And that means something important.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

“If a church truly centers itself on the cross...”

He paused.

“...then every disguise will eventually be exposed.”

No one spoke.

Because they all knew what that meant.

The cross does not merely forgive sin.

It reveals the flesh.

And when the flesh is revealed...

no system can protect it.

Adrián finally broke the silence.

“Well sir.”

He smiled faintly with a tear about to form in his eyes.

“That explains why the cross is rarely the center of church strategy meetings.”

No one laughed.

Because the thought was too accurate.

Chapter 26

The Cross Confronts Carnality



The next evening felt quieter than the others.

Not because the café was empty.

But because the conversation at the table had become more serious.

For several days they had been following a trail through Scripture.

Corinth.

Galatia.

Ephesus.

Laodicea.

Then the works of the flesh.

Then the cross.

Adrián finally spoke.

“So far we’ve said two things.”

Matías nodded.

“The cross does not bow to carnality.”

“And it is not deceived by it,” Elías added.

“Yes.”

Adrián looked at the open Bible.

“But that still leaves a question.”

“What question?” Marcos asked.

“What the cross actually does to it.”

The others waited.

Adrián continued.

“It exposes the flesh.”

“Yes.”

“But does it do anything beyond that?”

Marcos turned a few pages quietly.

“There is a passage that answers that directly.”

“Where,” Matías asked.

“Galatians again.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“That letter is becoming important.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“Very.”

He began reading slowly.

“Now those who belong to Christ Jesus have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires.”

The words sat heavily on the table.

Adrián spoke first.

“Crucified again.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“That language keeps appearing.”

Matías leaned forward slightly.

“That sounds decisive.”

Elías nodded.

“Crucifixion always is.”

Adrián rubbed his chin.

“But wait.”

He looked at the verse again.

“That says something important.”

“What,” Marcos asked.

“It says those who belong to Christ...”

“...have crucified the flesh.”

“Yes.”

“That sounds like something already accomplished.”

Marcos nodded.

“It does.”

Matías spoke slowly.

“So the cross does not merely confront carnality...”

“...it declares its end.”

No one spoke for a moment.

Because that thought was far more radical than anything they had discussed yet.

Adrián finally said it.

“That’s not how most churches talk about it.”

“No,” Elías said quietly, “in fact, i’ve never heard it said like that before.”

“What do they say?” Marcos asked.

Adrián answered without hesitation.

“They say we must constantly fight the flesh.”

Matías nodded.

“Yes.”

“That’s the language people use.”

“Fight it.”

“Resist it.”

“Control it.”

Marcos looked down at the passage again.

“But Paul says something different.”

“What,” Adrián asked.

“He says the flesh has been crucified.”

The table fell quiet.

Matías spoke carefully.

“That changes the entire picture.”

“How?” Adrián asked.

“If the flesh is already judged...”

He paused.

“...then the Christian life is not about improving it.”

Marcos nodded slowly.

“Wow. Let that thought simmer for a bit.”

“It is about recognizing what the cross has already done to it.”

Elías leaned back slightly.

“That would explain something.”

“What,” Matías asked.

“Why Paul never tries to train the flesh.”

Adrián looked puzzled.

“What do you mean?”

“In every letter...”

Elías continued,

“...Paul exposes the flesh.”

“He warns about it.”

“But he never tries to reform it.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes,, that’s true.”

“Because the cross has already pronounced its verdict.”

Adrián leaned back.

“So the cross confronts carnality by declaring it finished.”

“Man, let’s pickle in that a minute. That is powerful.”

Matías spoke quietly.

“That’s very different from carnality management.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

“Carnality management assumes the flesh must be controlled.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“While the cross assumes it has already been condemned.”

The words settled heavily.

Elías spoke slowly.

“That may be why the message of the cross always sounds ex-

treme.”

Adrián nodded.

“Yes.”

“Because it removes the entire middle ground.”

Matías looked thoughtful.

“No negotiation.”

“No improvement.”

“No compromise.”

Marcos nodded.

“Just crucifixion.”

The café noise continued around them.

But the table had grown very still.

Adrián finally spoke again.

“You know what this explains.”

“What,” Elías asked.

“Why people resist this message.”

“Why?”

“Because it leaves no place for pride.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

“And no place for human achievement.”

Marcos added quietly,

“And no place for the flesh to survive.”

The table fell quiet once more.

After a moment Adrián spoke again.

“So if the cross confronts carnality like this...”

He paused.

“...then the real question is not how to manage the flesh.”

The others looked at him.

Adrián finished the thought calmly.

“The real question is whether we believe what the cross has already done to it.”

No one answered immediately.

Because that question was no longer theoretical.

It was personal.

Chapter 27

The Cross Disarms Carnality



The conversation did not begin immediately that evening.

For once Adrián was the quiet one.

He sat staring into his coffee as the others arrived.

Matías noticed it first.

“You look like you’ve been thinking.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“That’s becoming a dangerous habit lately.”

Elías sat down and opened his Bible.

“What about?”

Adrián leaned back slowly.

“That verse from yesterday.”

“Which one?” Marcos asked.

“Those who belong to Christ Jesus have crucified
the flesh.”

Matías nodded.

“Yes.”

“That one has been sitting with me too.”

Adrián rubbed his forehead lightly.

“I’ve spent most of my life thinking about the flesh as something that must constantly overpower me.”

The others listened quietly.

“So the Christian life became a kind of endless struggle.”

Matías spoke carefully.

“That’s how most people describe it.”

“Yes.”

Adrián nodded.

“Fight harder.”

“Try harder.”

“Be more disciplined.”

Marcos leaned forward slightly.

“But Paul doesn’t describe it that way.”

“No,” Adrián said.

“That’s what’s bothering me.”

Elías turned to another passage.

“There’s something in Colossians that might help.”

Adrián smiled.

“Well sir, there have it. There usually is.”

Elías read slowly.

“When you were dead in your transgressions... God
made you alive together with Him...”

He paused briefly.

“...having forgiven us all our transgressions.”

Matías nodded.

“That’s the gospel.”

“Yes.”

“But keep listening,” Elías said.

He continued reading.

“Having canceled out the certificate of debt consisting of decrees against us...”

Adrián leaned forward slightly.

“That sounds like judgment being removed.”

“Yessss.”

Elías finished the sentence.

“He has taken it out of the way, having nailed it to the cross.”

The table was quiet.

Marcos spoke next.

“That’s decisive. That’s grace for you.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“But the passage continues.”

He read the next line carefully.

“When He had disarmed the rulers and authorities...”

Adrián blinked.

“Disarmed?”

“Yes.”

Elías continued.

“He made a public display of them, having triumphed over them through Him.”

The words sat heavily on the table.

Matías spoke slowly.

“That language sounds like victory.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“Something lost its power.”

Adrián leaned forward.

“So the cross doesn’t just expose carnality...”

“...it removes its authority.”

The others nodded.

Elías spoke quietly.

“That’s exactly what Paul is describing.”

Adrián thought for a moment.

“That explains something I’ve never understood.”

“What?” Matías asked.

“Why the New Testament keeps talking about freedom.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“Freedom from sin.”

“Freedom from the law.”

“Freedom from fear.”

Adrián rubbed his chin.

“But if the flesh is still powerful...”

He gestured slightly.

“...that language wouldn’t make sense. It’s almost offensive.”

Matías leaned back slowly.

“So the cross didn’t simply forgive us.”

“No,” Elías said.

“It disarmed what stood against us.”

The café noise filled the silence for a moment.

Then Marcos spoke again.

“That may explain why carnality often survives through intimidation.”

“What do you mean?” Adrián asked.

“Fear.”

“Pressure.”

“Condemnation.”

Matías nodded.

“Yes.”

“Those things control people.”

Adrián thought about that.

“So if the cross removes condemnation...”

“...then it removes one of the flesh’s greatest weapons.”

“Yes,” Marcos said.

Elías added quietly,

“And pride loses its ground as well.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“Because everything becomes grace.”

The table grew quiet again.

Adrián finally spoke.

“So carnality is not as powerful as it appears.”

“Not against grace,” Marcos said.

“It survives mostly through deception.”

Elías looked down at the open Bible again.

“That’s why Paul keeps returning to the cross.”

“What do you mean?” Matías asked.

“Because the cross reminds believers what has already happened.”

Adrián leaned back.

“So the flesh shouts...”

“...but the cross has already spoken.”

The others sat quietly with that thought.

After a moment Matías spoke again.

“That’s very different from how churches often approach the problem.”

“How so?” Adrián asked.

“They act as if the flesh must constantly be restrained.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“More rules.”

“More pressure.”

“More systems.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“But the cross removes its weapons.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“And once its authority is gone...”

He paused.

“...the entire struggle begins to look different.”

The table fell quiet again.

Adrián finally said what they were all beginning to sense.

“If the cross has disarmed carnality...”

He looked around the table.

“...then maybe the Christian life isn’t about strengthening ourselves against the flesh.”

The others watched him.

Adrián finished the thought slowly.

“Maybe it’s about living in what the cross has already accomplished.”

No one rushed to answer.

Because for the first time since the investigation began...

the problem of carnality no longer felt overwhelming.

It felt... defeated.

Chapter 28

The Cross Protects From Carnality



That evening the café was quieter than usual.

Not because fewer people were there.

But because the conversation at the table had slowed down.

For days the four men had been pressing into the same question.

Carnality.

They had seen it in Corinth.

They had seen it in Galatia.

They had seen it hidden behind discipline in Ephesus.

They had seen it thriving under activity in Laodicea.

And now the cross had entered the conversation.

Adrián broke the silence.

“So if the cross confronts carnality...”

He paused.

“And if the cross disarms it...”

He looked at the others.

“What does that mean for daily life?”

Matías nodded slowly.

“That’s the real question.”

Marcos flipped a few pages in his Bible.

“There’s a verse that might answer that.”

Adrián smiled.

“Another one?”

Marcos nodded.

“This one is simple.”

He read it slowly.

“But I say, walk by the Spirit, and you will not carry

out the desire of the flesh.”

Adrián looked up.

“That sounds almost too simple.”

“Yes,” Matías said.

“But listen carefully to how it works.”

Elías leaned forward.

“The verse does not say...”

He paused.

“...fight the flesh.”

Marcos nodded.

“It also does not say...”

“...focus on the flesh.”

Adrián looked down at the verse again.

“You’re right.”

“It says walk by the Spirit.”

Matías spoke slowly.

“That means the protection is not found in resisting the flesh.”

The others looked at him.

“It is found in walking somewhere else.”

Adrián leaned back in his chair.

“That’s very different from how most people describe the Christian life.”

“How so?” Marcos asked.

“Well,” Adrián said,

“I’ve heard a lot of sermons about guarding yourself from the flesh.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“Be careful.”

“Be alert.”

“Be on your guard.”

Matías nodded.

“Constant vigilance.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“But Paul doesn’t say that here.”

“No,” Marcos said.

“He redirects the focus.”

Elías read the verse again quietly.

“Walk by the Spirit...”

Adrián tapped the table lightly.

“That word walk is interesting.”

Matías nodded.

“Yes.”

“It suggests movement.”

“Daily life.”

“Ordinary steps.”

Marcos added,

“Not a battle posture.”

The table grew quiet.

Adrián finally spoke.

“So the cross protects us by redirecting our attention.”

“Yes,” Elías said.

“From the flesh...”

“...to the Spirit.”

Matías thought about that.

“That would explain something.”

“What?” Adrián asked.

“Why the more people focus on the flesh...”

“...the more powerful it appears.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“That’s often what happens.”

Adrián laughed softly.

“I’ve seen entire churches built around that idea.”

Matías smiled slightly.

“Carnality management.”

“Yes,” Adrián said.

“Endless strategies.”

“Endless warnings.”

“Endless pressure.”

Elías spoke quietly.

“But Paul’s instruction is surprisingly simple.”

Adrián looked at the verse again.

“Walk by the Spirit.”

Marcos nodded.

“And the result is stated clearly.”

Adrián finished the sentence.

“You will not carry out the desire of the flesh.”

The words hung in the air.

Matías spoke carefully.

“That’s not presented as a possibility.”

“No,” Marcos said.

“It’s presented as a certainty. There’s a promise there.”

Elías leaned back slightly.

“So the cross removes the authority of the flesh...”

“And the Spirit leads us away from it.”

Adrián nodded slowly.

“That sounds less like constant struggle...”

“...and more like protection.”

Matías smiled faintly.

“Yes.”

“Protection from something that has already been judged.”

The café noise filled the silence again.

Adrián spoke softly.

“That’s beginning to feel different.”

“How?” Marcos asked.

“For the first time in this conversation...”

Adrián paused.

“...the flesh doesn’t feel like the center of everything.”

The others nodded.

Matías spoke quietly.

“And maybe that’s exactly the point.”

The table grew still again.

Adrián looked around at the others.

“So if the cross confronts carnality...”

“...and disarms it...”

“...and protects us from it...”

He paused.

“That leaves one final question.”

“What question?” Elías asked.

Adrián smiled slightly.

“If the cross has done all this...”

“...why do so many churches still spend their energy managing the flesh?”

No one answered immediately.

Because that question was about to lead them somewhere deeper.

Chapter 29

Why Carnality Management Still Exists



The café was louder that night.

A group at the far table was laughing loudly.

Someone behind the counter dropped a tray.

But the four men at their usual table barely noticed.

Adrián was the first to speak.

“I keep coming back to the same question.”

Matías looked up.

“Which one?”

Adrián rested his elbows on the table.

“If the cross has confronted the flesh...”

“...and disarmed it...”

“...and if walking in the Spirit protects us from it...”

He paused.

“Then why do so many churches organize their entire life around controlling carnality?”

The others exchanged glances.

Because they all knew the answer might be uncomfortable.

Marcos finally spoke.

“Maybe because people don’t believe the cross has really dealt with it.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

“If you assume the flesh is still the main power in the Christian life...”

“...then you have no choice but to manage it.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“That sounds familiar.”

Elías looked at him.

“What do you mean?”

“I’ve heard statements like that my whole life.”

He began counting on his fingers.

“I believe in grace...”

He paused.

“...but I’d never teach it.”

The others nodded immediately.

Adrián continued.

“People would take advantage.”

Matías leaned back slightly.

“Yes.”

“That’s a very common fear.”

Marcos added quietly,

“It assumes the flesh must constantly be restrained.”

Adrián nodded.

“And then someone inevitably asks the next question.”

“What question?” Elías asked.

Adrián smiled.

“Where do you draw the line?”

The table grew quiet.

Matías shook his head slightly.

“That phrase alone has shaped entire church cultures.”

“How so?” Marcos asked.

“Because the secret genius of leadership...”

Matías paused.

“...is assumed to be knowing where to draw the line.”

Adrián laughed softly.

“Yes.”

“Just enough rules to keep people in check.”

Marcos looked thoughtful.

“But the cross doesn’t operate that way.”

“No,” Elías said.

“The cross removes the entire system of line-drawing.”

Adrián nodded slowly.

“And that makes people nervous.”

Matías spoke quietly.

“Yes.”

“Very nervous.” He looked around to see if anyone was listening.

Adrián continued.

“So what happens?”

“Churches build systems.”

“Rules.”

“Safeguards.”

“Accountability structures.”

Marcos nodded.

“Carnality management.”

Elías added quietly,

“And it often sounds very spiritual.”

Adrián smiled.

“Yes.”

“Grace is good...”

He raised an eyebrow.

“...but you can’t be without the law.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“I’ve heard that sentence countless times.”

Marcos added,

“And then someone else says...”

“Grace, grace, grace.”

“All you talk about is grace.”

Adrián leaned back in his chair.

“Yes.”

“As if grace itself were the danger.”

The table fell quiet for a moment.

Matías spoke next.

“And when someone questions the system...”

Adrián finished the sentence.

“They’re accused of dividing the church.”

Elías nodded.

“Yes.”

“Unity must be protected.”

Marcos spoke carefully.

“But unity at the expense of truth...”

“...is not unity.”

Adrián smiled faintly.

“Try telling that to a church meeting.”

The others laughed quietly.

Matías spoke again.

“Sometimes the accusations become stronger.”

Adrián nodded.

“Yes.”

“That’s hyper-grace.”

Elías raised an eyebrow.

“And no one can define what that means.”

Marcos smiled.

“Or this one.”

“That’s antinomian.”

Matías chuckled softly.

“Another label.”

“But rarely explained.”

Adrián leaned forward.

“And when Scripture is brought up...”

He paused.

“...the response can become even more revealing.”

“What do you mean?” Marcos asked.

Adrián shrugged.

“I’ve actually heard someone say it.”

“What?”

Adrián shook his head slightly.

“I don’t care what the Bible says.”

The others looked at him confused.

Adrián finished the sentence quietly.

“This is how it’s always been and that’s how it will remain.”

No one spoke for a moment.

Because they had all heard something similar.

Matías finally spoke.

“That may be the real reason carnality management survives.”

“How so?” Elías asked.

“Because systems feel safer than the cross.”

Marcos nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

“Systems give leaders control.”

Adrián added quietly,

“And they give the flesh somewhere to hide.”

The café noise continued around them.

But the table had grown very still again.

Adrián finally spoke.

“So maybe that’s the real issue.”

“What is?” Matías asked.

Adrián answered calmly.

“Carnality management exists...”

He paused.

“...because people don’t fully trust what the cross has already done.”

The others sat quietly with that thought.

Because it was becoming clearer with every conversation.

The cross had already spoken.

But many churches had built entire structures to avoid believing it.

Chapter 30

Grace Has Made the Difference



The conversation that evening began slowly.

Not because the men had nothing to say.

But because they had said so much already.

For days they had traced the problem of carnality through the Scriptures.

Corinth had shown them carnality in open immorality.

Galatia had shown them carnality hidden behind moral seriousness.

Ephesus had revealed carnality disguised as doctrinal devotion.

Laodicea had exposed carnality thriving in religious success.

And every path had eventually led them back to the same place.

The cross.

Adrián spoke first.

“So if everything we’ve said is true...”

He paused.

“...then the real difference must be grace.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

“But not the way people usually talk about grace.”

Marcos leaned forward.

“What do you mean?”

Matías thought for a moment.

“Grace is often treated like forgiveness.”

Adrián nodded.

“Yes.”

“Exactly, something that helps when we fail.”

Elías added quietly,

“A safety net.”

Marcos looked down at the open Bible.

“But Paul speaks of grace very differently.”

Adrián raised an eyebrow.

“How?”

Marcos turned a few pages and read aloud.

“For the grace of God has appeared, bringing salvation to all men...”

He paused.

Then continued.

“...instructing us to deny ungodliness and worldly desires...”

The others leaned closer.

Marcos finished the sentence.

“...and to live sensibly, righteously and godly in the present age.”

The words lingered for a moment.

Adrián spoke softly.

“That sounds active.”

Matías nodded.

“Yes.”

“Grace is not passive.”

Elías added quietly,

“It actually teaches.”

Marcos looked exited.

“So grace doesn’t excuse carnality.”

“No,” Matías said.

“It replaces it.”

Adrián leaned back.

“That changes the entire picture.”

“How?” Elías asked.

“If grace is only forgiveness...”

Adrián shrugged.

“...then the Christian life becomes constant failure.”

Marcos nodded.

“Yes.”

“Fall.”

“Confess.”

“Start again.”

Matías spoke slowly.

“But if grace is the power of God...”

“...then something deeper is happening.”

The others looked at him.

“What do you mean?” Adrián asked.

Matías gestured toward the Bible.

“Grace doesn’t merely pardon the old life.”

He paused.

“It produces a new one.”

The table fell quiet again.

Elías finally spoke.

“That would explain why Paul speaks so confidently.”

Adrián nodded.

“Yes.”

“Sometimes almost shockingly so.”

Marcos smiled slightly.

“Like Romans.”

Adrián laughed softly.

“Yes.”

“Romans.”

He quoted from memory with a sparkle in his eye.

“Sin shall not be master over you, for you are not under law but under grace.”

Matías nodded slowly.

“That statement only makes sense if grace actually changes something.”

Elías leaned forward slightly.

“It removes the entire framework of carnality management.”

Marcos added,

“And replaces it with life in the Spirit.”

Adrián looked around the table.

“So the gospel was never meant to produce controlled carnality.”

The others shook their heads.

“No.”

“It produces something else.”

Matías spoke quietly.

“A different kind of life.”

Elías nodded.

“Yes.”

“A life that flows from the cross.”

Adrián rubbed his chin.

“That explains something.”

“What?” Marcos asked.

“Why the New Testament speaks so often about fruit.”

Matías smiled.

“Yes.”

“Fruit.”

“Not effort.”

“Not systems.”

“Fruit.”

Elías added quietly,

“And fruit grows from life.”

The café noise continued around them.

But the table had grown still once again.

Adrián finally spoke.

“You know what surprises me the most.”

“What?” Matías asked.

“That this solution was sitting in front of us the entire time.”

Marcos nodded slowly.

“Yes.”

“The cross.”

“The gospel.”

“Grace.”

Elías smiled faintly.

“And we kept looking somewhere else.”

Adrián laughed softly.

“Trying to solve the problem.”

Matías nodded.

“When the answer had already been given.”

The four men sat quietly for a moment.

Because the conversation had reached a place they had not expected when it began.

Not a new system.

Not a better strategy.

But something far simpler.

And far more powerful.

Adrián finally said it out loud.

“So the difference...”

He paused.

“...has always been grace.”

No one argued.

Because by now it was becoming clear.

Grace had not merely forgiven them.

Grace had changed everything.

Chapter 31

What I Learned About the Carnal Church



For many evenings I sat nearby and listened.

The four men never noticed me.

They were too engaged with one another.

At first their conversations seemed ordinary. Friends meeting after their travels, sharing stories about churches they had visited.

But slowly the conversation changed.

What began as casual observations became an investigation.

One by one the churches were discussed.

Corinth.

Galatia.

Ephesus.

Laodicea.

At first the differences between them seemed obvious.

Corinth was openly troubled.

Galatia was intensely serious.

Ephesus was doctrinally careful.

Laodicea appeared strong and successful.

But as the conversation continued, something unexpected began to appear.

Underneath the differences, the same problem kept surfacing.

Carnality.

Not always obvious.

Not always scandalous.

Sometimes loud.

Sometimes respectable.

But always present.

At first the men tried to understand it through experience.

They spoke about churches.

About leadership.

About discipline.

About unity.

About success.

About failure.

They repeated phrases most of us have heard before.

“Where do you draw the line?”

“I believe in grace, but people will abuse it.”

“We must protect unity.”

“Grace is good, but you can’t be without the law.”

“We just need to try harder.”

All of it sounded familiar.

Because most churches have built their lives around managing carnality.

Systems are created.

Rules are added.

Pressure is applied.

The flesh is restrained, corrected, warned, and disciplined.

But rarely understood.

That was the turning point of the conversation.

When the men finally asked a simple question:

What does the Bible actually mean by “flesh”?

That question led them back to Scripture.

And once they began observing carefully, the picture became clearer.

Carnality is not limited to immorality.

Corinth proved that.

But neither is carnality limited to moral looseness.

Galatia proved that.

Carnality can also appear in devotion to doctrine.

Ephesus showed that.

And it can flourish inside religious success.

Laodicea demonstrated that.

Different expressions.

The same root.

The flesh.

For a time the conversation seemed stuck there.

If carnality could appear in so many forms, what hope was there for the church?

That is when the cross entered the discussion.

Not as a slogan.

Not as a theological statement.

But as the decisive act of God.

The cross does not negotiate with the flesh.

It does not reform it.

It does not manage it.

The cross condemns it.

Those who belong to Christ Jesus have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires.

Once that truth became clear, many other passages suddenly made sense.

The cross confronts carnality.

The cross disarms it.

The cross protects the believer from it.

And grace, flowing from the cross, produces something entirely different.

Not managed carnality.

New life.

That is the difference the men slowly began to see.

The gospel is not merely forgiveness for failure.

It is the power of God unto salvation.

A salvation that reaches into daily life.

A salvation that produces fruit.

A salvation that leads believers to walk by the Spirit rather than constantly struggle with the flesh.

For years many churches have assumed that carnality is simply part of the Christian experience.

Something to manage.

Something to restrain.

Something to keep under control.

But the cross tells a different story.

The flesh has already been judged.

And grace has already been given.

The question is no longer whether the cross has spoken.

The question is whether we believe what it has said.

The four men eventually left the café that evening.

Their investigation had not produced a new system.

It had not produced a better strategy.

But it had revealed something far more important.

The answer had been present all along.

The cross.

And the grace that flows from it.

That grace has made all the difference.

I will end this with a question.

One that comes from years of struggle, frustration, and hurt.

Years of hurting myself and, at times, hurting those around me as well.

I really tried.

For a long time I believed the answer was simply to try harder, to do better, to be more disciplined, more committed, more serious.

And I did try.

But after years of trying, I eventually had to face a painful truth.

I had failed.

Not once or twice, but again and again.

And yet, in that place of failure, God was gracious to meet me where I was.

Grace met me where I was.

It did not wait for me to measure up.

It did not demand that I first become what I could never make myself to be.

It met me there.

And that changed everything.

So let me ask you a simple question.

If the cross has already judged the flesh... why are we still trying to manage it?

Thanks for reading.

If this book helped you, share it with someone who is dealing
with the same questions.

Some parts of this manuscript were developed with the help of AI-based
language tools used for writing, editing, and translation. All ideas,
arguments, and conclusions belong to the author.